

Tomorrow's Child

April 2012

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**A Publication of
The Montessori
Foundation**

In this issue ...

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Why Not Montessori?**

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Dear Readers:

Every day, I drive past a shrine with two crosses on the side of the road. It is decorated with balloons, flowers, stuffed animals, and signs. On Christmas Eve, a car carrying three teenagers from the local high school was "T-boned" on our very busy state road. They were not at fault; the other driver just wasn't paying attention. Two of the students died **not** from the injuries sustained in the car but from being thrown from the car because they were not wearing seat belts. The student wearing a seat belt survived. Three months after the accident, the shrine remains, a reminder to us to of the fragility of life.

So, what does this have to do with Montessori? In this issue, there are a number of articles exploring a similar theme involving the need for a paradigm shift to bring Montessori into more traditional, mainstream environments.

Maria Montessori believed that by treating children holistically with respect, creating an environment that allowed learning to take place without damaging the spirit, and building a strong foundation of self-esteem could change the world. For those of us involved in Montessori, it is painful to know how much the lives of children could be enhanced if only they could experience a different learning environment.

Going back to the shrine, the seatbelts, and the needless loss of young life ...

Seatbelts are a relatively new requirement for cars. They had been in existence for about 40 years before they became mandatory for US-manufactured cars in 1984. Why did it take so long, and why is it that some people still don't wear them?

Today, we take a lot for granted when it comes to our vehicular well-being: seatbelts, airbags, shatterproof glass. When seatbelts were first introduced, the car manufacturers were not happy about the added cost. Consumers were not happy about the added cost. Many people just couldn't wrap their heads around strapping themselves into their car. *Seatbelts chafe my skin. Seatbelts won't let me escape from the car if I'm in an accident. I'm a careful driver; why would I need a seatbelt?* These are just some of the many reasons my own father gave for not wearing a seatbelt. It has now become so deeply ingrained in our culture, personal habits, and muscle memory that most of us wouldn't think of even backing down the driveway without buckling up. Here is evidence that a cultural paradigm has quietly taken place.

Human beings are a stubborn species, but here is evidence that sometimes common sense sometimes does prevail — even if it costs a little more. Perhaps greater recognition and acceptance of the Montessori Method will be next — even if it costs a little more.

Have a wonderful summer break (at least for our readers in the Northern Hemisphere). The next issue of *Tomorrow's Child* will be in September.

—Joyce St. Giermaine, Editor



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**Why
Montessori?**

**Why Not
Montessori?**

**Educating &
Parenting as if
The Spirit in
Each Child
Matters**

**Joyce St. Giermaine,
Editor & Executive
Director, The Montessori
Foundation**

The child is much more spiritually elevated than is usually supposed. He often suffers, not from too much work, but from work that is unworthy of him.

There is a part of a child's soul that has always been unknown but which must be known. With a spirit of sacrifice and enthusiasm we must go in search, like those who travel to foreign lands and tear up mountains in their search for hidden gold.

In their dealings with children, adults do not become egotistic but egocentric. They look upon everything pertaining to a child's soul from their own point of view and, consequently, their misapprehensions increase."

— Maria Montessori

On a long car ride back from a meeting with new friends who wanted to talk about Montessori, I asked my husband, Tim Seldin (President of The Montessori Foundation) why he had devoted his life to Montessori. His answer was quick: "I see Montessori as the best hope for saving our planet."

The gist of our meeting that morning had been a discussion about the resistance from mainstream education to embrace Montessori (even after more than 100 years) and the frustration of just finding common ground among the various Montessori professional organizations to agree on a definition of "authentic Montessori."

So, at the risk of being politically incorrect, I'd like to offer the following thoughts after observing Montessori for the past twenty-plus years as Executive Director of The Montessori Foundation along with some new personal insights into the continuing value of Maria Montessori's brave and groundbreaking work.

Why is Montessori relevant?

Montessori is relevant because the world is in crisis. This crisis is pandemic and, like a virus, it is moving swiftly, so swiftly that our governments, our schools, and our families cannot keep up. It is hitting us from the air that we breathe, to the food we feed our children, to the price of gas we need to get to work, to having a job at all. Despite the many ways in which we have tried to solve these problems, nothing seem to work — or last. Clearly, we need to consider new ways to effect change on both short- and long-term bases. We need a paradigm shift on a large scale that goes beyond who we elect to govern us. We have to start with ourselves, our families, and our children.

We have become so frantic about our personal survival that we have lost sight of the bigger picture. We have speeded up our lives to the point that it has all become a blur. We are running so fast that we don't even know where we are going anymore. Myself included! Are we trying to be the first to cross the finish line, or are we actually running in an attempt to escape? When we are in competition with ourselves, there can be no winners.

Montessori the Activist

Maria Montessori died the year I was born (sixty years ago). She became a doctor when women were still treated as inferior to men in every way except child bearing.

In 1896, Montessori became the first woman in Italy to receive the degree of Doctor of Medicine. This, of course, attracted a fair amount of attention from the press, and she soon became somewhat of a celebrity. She also was chosen to represent the women of Italy at a feminist congress and became a strong advocate for the rights of women and children.

Shortly after graduation from medical school, Montessori was given her first assignment as assistant doctor at the Psychiatric Clinic of the University of Rome. Through her work, she often visited Rome's asylums for children considered insane or mentally retarded. In the clinic, Montessori found herself confronted by a group of children who presented with profound mental, psychological, and physical disabilities. It really was a 'hard-

ship' assignment, and I can't help but imagine that she may have received that position due in large part to the fact that she *was* a woman, and I also suspect that she was set up to fail.

Under Montessori's guidance, the 'clinic' transitioned into an orthophrenic 'school' that helped children to better themselves in whatever way they could to become more functional members of society. Clearly, many of the existing staff members, who referred to their young patients as "animals," resented Montessori and the changes in management she represented.

Although faced with an almost impossible challenge, Montessori not only rose to the occasion but came to the astounding conclusion that what society saw as mental deficiencies were not just medical but, instead, pedagogical issues. This conclusion required a complete shift in the manner in which the staff worked and interacted with these disabled people. To the shock of everyone, Montessori achieved a remarkable degree of success with these 'unteachables.' In fact, the press called her success a "miracle."

It was during this same timeframe that Montessori began to research the studies of other professionals interested in the study of children with disabilities, specifically the work of Jean Itard and Eduard Sequin, innovative educators of their

Maria Montessori: Medical School, Cadavers in the Dark, a Plea to the Pope, & a Chance Encounter with a Gypsy Child

Maria Montessori was born in 1870 in the Province of Ancona, Italy. Although her parents encouraged her educational pursuits, they hoped that she would become a teacher, a career 'appropriate' for young women of her age. She refused and continued to follow her interest in math and science, eventually applying to the Medical School of Rome. Rejected, she appealed the school's decision and even brought her frustration to the attention of the Pope. Eventually, she was accepted and become Italy's first female medical student.

Not unexpectedly, her presence was resented, and she endured many indignities from the male students, so much so that she almost quit; however, a chance encounter may have changed her life and set her on the path to study the secret world of children and become the creator of a new method of education combining science and pedagogy.

Montessori was not allowed to participate in the dissection classes along with her male colleagues; instead, she was only allowed access to the cadavers at night, by herself, in the school's basement. One night working alone with the dead, Montessori simply felt that she could no longer take the abuse, humiliation, and loneliness (including an estrangement from her father, who disapproved of her career choice). Running out into the night, gasping for fresh air, she discovered herself in the open space of a park across the street.

In the darkly illuminated park, she encountered a Gypsy woman and her young daughter. The little girl (a toddler) was deep in concentration, as her tiny hands manipulated a brightly colored ribbon (although some accounts describe the material as pieces of colored paper): swirling it, rolling it, straightening it out, rearranging it, using what we now call fine-motor skills. It was, perhaps, Maria Montessori's 'aha' moment. I don't know if the child ignited Montessori's curiosity or if she saw herself and other young girls in that toddler, but she turned around and went back to the basement and her studies with a new resolve to persevere. Her father is said to have finally come around as he listened to his daughter's valedictorian graduation address!



time. Montessori sought out these fellow travelers who had found success with disabled children, including the blind, working with materials that were soon to become Montessori's Movable alphabet and Sandpaper Letters. She found their contributions so important, yet undervalued, that she, herself hand transcribed their work so that it would not be lost. In the process of expanding her own knowledge, she became even more convinced of the correlation of science and pedagogy and the importance of paying careful attention to even the smallest details.

A Scandal that Could Have Ended Montessori's Career

After her success working with disabled children and her continuing research into the work of Itard and Sequin, varying accounts report that Montessori retreated to the countryside to allow herself a "time of reflection." It was during this period that Montessori gave birth to her son, Mario (1898 - 1982), the father of whom was a fellow physician who was also very involved in the same philosophical, medical, and social issues that consumed Montessori.

While this seems of little importance to us in the 21st century, an unwed mother in such a professional and public position would have certainly been ostracized and condemned. In short, a baby out of wedlock would have been the end of her career. She and the baby's father reputedly made a pact that neither would marry (a very grand, egalitarian gesture for the time). While Maria kept her promise, Mario's father did not. Once again, Montessori felt the sting of sexism as she resigned herself to the need to conform to the social necessity of becoming 'aunt' to her own child.

Although, she could not directly participate in Mario's life as his mother, Montessori did have the opportunity to spend time with him and watch him grow. In the process, she became even more interested in the physical, psychological, and spiritual development of the young child. Maria and Mario's true relationship was not revealed to him until he was 15 years old. How sadly ironic that someone who did so much for other people's children could not openly embrace her own child when he was young. Perhaps this only made their later personal and professional relationship all that much sweeter. From

what I have read, Mario became what we'd refer to today as Maria's 'rock.'

Marilena Henny (Montessori) Mario's daughter and Maria's granddaughter speaks fondly of her father (www.montessori-ami.org):

He was a born teacher. He loved children and especially tiny babies whom he called miracle makers, and with whom he held long conversations, which the newborns, staring at his lips, followed with fascination.

But all his many loves were nothing compared to his love for his mother and her work. An all-encompassing love which dominated his whole existence. His dedication to her was conscious and free choice, not a result of mother/son attachment. After all he was almost fifteen years old when he first knew and lived with her — too late in life to grow a subconscious Oedipus complex. She had no place in his absorbent-mind period. There could have been no question on either side of being unable to sever the umbilical cord. He lived for her, with her but not through her. The amazing thing about this man with no real scholastic or academic background was the clarity of his total understanding of the working of her mind. His intuitive intelligence and openness of spirit allowed him to keep abreast with her quantum leaps from the first to the nth dimension - even sometimes arriving just ahead, thus enabling her to soar even further. Nothing she deduced, developed, or stated ever surprised him.

Finally — the Opportunity to Work with "Normal" Children

Eventually, Montessori returned to work and began to search for her next career opportunity. After observing how well her new techniques worked with children with profound disabilities, Montessori began to lobby for a chance to try out her theories on 'normal' children. Finally, persistence paid off and a group of businessmen asked her to become director of a daycare program for the children of factory workers, who were too young to attend school and who were running amok while their parents were at work during the day. It sounds a lot like a virtual "Lord-of-the-Flies" situation with bored, dirty, hungry children playing in filth, urinating in the hallways, fighting with each other, and causing destruction to property.

Ironically, teaching children was the one career option that Montessori had always rejected. Even if she had wanted to be a

teacher, can you imagine walking into a situation where you were responsible for a pack of unruly, unwashed street urchins? Regardless of the difficulties, she began the process of creating order out of chaos.

She studied these disadvantaged, inner-city children with the skills of a researcher and, in that process of scientific inquiry, discovered that there was a lot more going on in the minds of these young humans than even she had previously understood. Then, doing what we now refer to as "following the child," she figured out an alternative way to tap into the hidden potential she now saw in each child. Beginning with what we would now call 'Practical Life,' Montessori taught the more capable, older children to help care for the younger ones, and everyone became involved in the daily upkeep of their classroom environment: cooking, cleaning and taking care of each other with what has now become 'Grace and Courtesy.'

While creating the Montessori Method may not be as exciting as inventing Facebook™ or discovering a new solar system, when you think back to the not-so-distant "children-should-be-seen-but-not heard" "spare-the-rod-and-spoil-the-child" method of parenting and educating, Montessori's findings were quite revolutionary. Children were capable of independent thought, compassion for others, yearned for self-respect and autonomy, and enjoyed working with their minds and their hands! Who knew?

At first, Montessori was praised because of the results she achieved. Then, she fell out of favor and, to a real extent, she has remained out of favor except for a relatively small, brave band of worldwide followers (readers included). She was nominated for the Nobel Peace Prize (three times!) for her work on behalf of women, children, and the anti-war movement. Her Method, although never receiving the recognition it deserved, has been copied, plagiarized, cannibalized, and given sexy new labels over the years by other educators and government programs trying to achieve better test scores.

What these imitators didn't (and don't) understand is that Montessori's Method is a complete, scientifically designed program of working with children at critical points in their development in a very well-

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defined environment that provides the materials and trained guides, *all* of which are needed to achieve success.

Maria Montessori was a scientist. She developed, through trial and error, a program that worked. Like a scientific formula that shows us how to split an atom or a recipe for the perfect chocolate cake, it just doesn't work to substitute or leave out key ingredients. This takes time, money, and commitment. There are no shortcuts.

Why is there so much resistance to Implementing Montessori in our schools?

The answer is both easy and complicated. The 'easy' answer is that Montessori is expensive. Before becoming certified, a Montessori teacher must have already obtained at least a bachelor's degree, received upwards of 60 hours in post-graduate training from an accredited Montessori teacher training program, and then served at least a year-long in-class internship under the supervision of a master Montessori educator. It is expensive, time-consuming, and often logistically impractical.

This is why, there is a growing appeal to apply the use of high-speed internet and the ability to combine onsite and distance-learning Montessori teacher-training programs. To meet this need, there are now MACTE (Montessori Accreditation Council for Teacher Education) accredited programs for Primary through Upper Elementary certification. (www.guided-studies.com).

Then there is the cost of the materials ...

In many ways, the value of the Montessori material is only as high as the training of the Montessori guides who work in the classrooms. Without trained guides, it's like having a beautiful concert-quality baby grand piano but not knowing how to play, and, yes, there actually is a real difference between high-quality Montessori materials and cheap imitations.

Like the weight and substance of elegant cutlery, the way it rests and balances in your hand, even the untrained can feel the difference in the quality of Montessori materials. Take a look at the bead cabinet someday. If your school is fortunate to

have real glass beads, hold them in your hand. Feel the weight and the smoothness. Now imagine the same material, this time manufactured in plastic or ceramic. It's rough. The color's a bit off. Without the weight, it doesn't hang or lay properly. Now imagine that you're not an adult, but, instead a small child with just the beginning of fine-motor skills, and you need that extra bit of substance to make the material work just right with your clumsy hands. Or take a look at a Pink Tower in your child's classroom. For it to balance properly, it needs to be solid wood, and wood is expensive.

Classrooms need to be larger, too. Why? Because Montessori children are encouraged to move around. You can pack a lot more kids into neat rows of desks than providing space for the child who likes to work spread out, tummy to the floor.

Challenges & Opportunities – The More Complicated Reasons

Now that we've established the basic costs of Montessori that are readily understood, let's look at the hidden resistance.

Our culture, at least here in North America, is so heavily invested in the traditional forms of 'kill and drill' to succeed in standardized testing that it is simply too overwhelming to consider the cost and work involved with all the changes needed to implement Montessori on a large scale. Add to that the need to convince influence powerful teacher unions and even confront the incredibly lucrative field of the textbook industry that may have cornered the market on the one and only text selected for one particular subject that is used throughout the country.

It is also very challenging for Montessori schools to convince state officials that Montessori children are being adequately educated by this alternative method and that results on standardized tests are arbitrary at best and generally not valuable. For this argument, we need more research, but research is also extremely expensive. For more information on research, pick up Angelina Lillard's book, *Montessori: The Science behind the Genius*.

Instead of battling the system, there is a

need for Montessori schools to work with each state's department of education to provide a detailed Montessori curriculum that responds to the state curriculum concerns, demonstrating ways in which Montessori is able to align its curriculum without compromising on the important principles that define Montessori. This work is now being done on a state by state level (see article on *Scope and Sequence* in this issue, page 27).

Finding a way to work with the system and with each other will help all Montessori schools navigate the ins and outs of bringing Montessori more into the mainstream of education.

Montessori Works: Get On with It

Montessori came to understand that each child had the spark of genius and the potential to become a unique, contributing member of the world community, if given the chance to develop. I wonder if she saw in these children the opportunities she wished she could have experienced as a child. Instead of beating them (literally and figuratively) into compliance, she created ways to empower children with the self-esteem and tools that allowed them to become active participants in their own growth and transformation.

Montessori's findings were clearly ahead of her time. It's good to remember how many truths we take for granted now without acknowledging the incredible cultural revolutions that needed to take place before these concepts became reality. How could we (can we) ever have rationalized that one race, religion, or gender is of greater or lesser value? But we did and still do. People of color were considered chattel.

Women, in general, didn't fare much better and couldn't vote, obtain higher education, or own property. In the early 1900s, the concept that children deserved to be heard and respected must have been just as revolutionary as the earlier attempts to abolish slavery or give women the right to vote. And just as scary. Give people a voice, and the next thing you know, women will be running corporations and becoming doctors, and people of color will be able to own property, vote, and might just get elected to run countries. And, as for children, who knows what they might accomplish if they were not treated as one of a billion small, invisible cogs in a system that

requires everyone to be on exactly the same page on any given day?

Is it at all conceivable that Maria Montessori's thoughts about the empowerment of children and women were just too politically incorrect for the time in which she lived? In the early 1900s, as government-sponsored educational 'reform' was striving to create a new generation of factory workers who would be content to serve their time on the assembly line, Maria Montessori was looking for generations of children who would become thinkers and activists — children who would grow up *with* the tools (not *as* the tools) and knowledge that they could change their (and our) world for the better.

It Takes the 'Right' Parent and a Brave Parent to Choose Montessori for Their Child

While it might be argued that Montessori is effective for almost any child, it is not the right choice for every family. Parents who want instant validation for their child should not choose Montessori, because Montessori did not (and does not) consider genius to be rare.

Montessori's work with children gave her the insight that every child was endowed with gifts and talents that were their's alone. This sounds good, but is it realistic? The desire to allow every person to succeed and live to their fullest potential is something that we give lip service to, but something that actually scares most of us. It is sad but true (at least in my experience) that it is simply not within our human nature to invest ourselves in the success of others. Are we happy that our best friend wins the lottery, or are we jealous? Are we thrilled that our sister's children have been accepted into a gifted and tal-

ent program, but our own children are 'just' happy, well-adjusted kids working 'just' at or slightly above grade level?

Instead of worrying about what college our preschooler will attend, how would our world change if we looked deeply into the eyes of each three-year-old with an open mind and asked the questions: *Who are you? What wonderful gift do you have to contribute to your family, your school, your community, your planet? How can I help you succeed?*

Who will your child become? While I'm not an advocate for free-range parenting, there seems a real need to find some sane way to keep the innate spirit of uniqueness alive and functioning in our children. These are the same people who will grow up to become the leaders of tomorrow, the caretakers of our future.

Montessori wrote: "There is in the soul of a child an impenetrable secret that is gradually revealed as it develops." To me, this implies that a child needs the time, the opportunity, and the resources to explore the gifts with which he was born, not simply to conform as one of the herd.

A well-run Montessori classroom and understanding parents have to be willing to trust and say: *Here are the tools; here is the environment; here is our support and love ... now show us what you've got!*

That's a big leap of faith for most parents. It wasn't the way we were raised (and look how well we turned out!). Well, let's take a closer look at that concept. How many of us honestly find our jobs/careers rewarding? How many of us actually define our greatest potential and value by the amount of our next paycheck? When

it comes time for our life to end, what can we say we did that made a positive difference even in our own little carbon footprint on this planet? Do we really not want more for our children and grandchildren?

Montessori is a Movement that Might Change the World

It might be argued that Montessori has not been adopted on a grand scale, not because it doesn't work, but because it does. If more children had access to Montessori, the world might change, and change is threatening.

The fact that it has not become mainstream requires even those of us who really value our children's future to continue to defend the ways in which we have chosen to interact with our very young. We need to be their advocate and protect their creativity. We need to safeguard their dreams and potential until they are strong enough to defend their uniqueness on their own

Montessori, during her lifetime, gave voice to those who had no voice. One hundred years later, now, more than ever, we need children who will become adults who can bring their skills and compassion to solve problems and serve as the catalyst for the next paradigm shift: creating a new way of living together on this planet that is based on dignity for all, respect, partnership, and collaboration.

If one person can change the world, what could we accomplish collectively?

Dare to become a Montessori activist for our children. Together, we might just change the world. ♦

Joyce and her husband, Tim, live in Florida with many dogs, horses, naked cats (Sphynx) and (currently) a herd of wild boar that has decided to make her 20 acres 'home.'

Her children both attended Montessori school through the eighth grade, and one is now a Montessori teacher.

Needing a photo for this article, she only momentarily hesitated to exploit her grandchild (Jackson) (naked baby on page 5) so that she can embarrass him when he becomes a teenager. (Photo by Blair Banks, Baltimore, MD)



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Well, "Duh!"

10 Obvious Truths That We Shouldn't Be Ignoring

by Alfie Kohn

The field of education bubbles over with controversies. It's not unusual for intelligent people of good will to disagree passionately about what should happen in schools. But there are certain precepts that aren't debatable, that just about anyone would have to acknowledge are true.

While many such statements are banal, some are worth noticing because in our school practices and policies, we tend to ignore the implications that follow from them. It's both intellectually interesting and practically important to explore such contradictions: If we all agree that a given principle is true, then why in the world do our schools still function as if it weren't?

Here are 10 examples.

1. Much of the material students are required to memorize is soon forgotten.

The truth of this statement will be conceded (either willingly or reluctantly) by just about everyone who has spent time in school — in other words, all of us. A few months, or sometimes even just a few days, after having committed a list of facts, dates, or definitions to memory, we couldn't recall most of them if our lives depended on it. Everyone knows this, yet a substantial part of schooling — particularly in the most traditional schools — continues to consist of stuffing facts into students' short-term memories.

The more closely we inspect this model of teaching and testing, the more problematic it reveals itself to be. First, there's the question of what students are made to learn, which often is more oriented to factual material than to a deep understanding of ideas. (See item 2, below.) Second, there's the question of how students are taught, with a focus on passive absorption: listening to lectures, reading summaries in textbooks, and rehearsing material immediately before being required to cough it back up. Third, there's the question of why a student has learned something: Knowledge is less likely to be retained if it has been acquired so that one will per-

This essay is an abridged version of the introduction to Feel-Bad Education . . . And Other Contrarian Essays on Children and Schooling (Beacon Press, 2011)

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form well on a test, as opposed to learning in the context of pursuing projects and solving problems that are personally meaningful.

Even without these layers of deficiencies with the status quo, and even if we grant that remembering some things can be useful, the fundamental question echoes like a shout down an endless school corridor: *Why are kids still being forced to memorize so much stuff that we know they won't remember?*

Corollary 1A: Since this appears to be true for adults, too, why do most professional development events for teachers resemble the least impressive classrooms, with experts disgorging facts about how to educate?

2. Just knowing a lot of facts doesn't mean you're smart.

Even students who do manage to remember some of the material they were taught are not necessarily able to make sense of those bits of knowledge, to understand connections among them, or to apply them in inventive and persuasive ways to real-life problems.

In fact, the cognitive scientist Lauren Resnick goes even further: It's not just that knowing (or having been taught) facts doesn't in itself make you smart. A mostly fact-oriented education may actually interfere with your becoming smart. "Thinking skills tend to be driven out of the curriculum by ever-growing demands for teaching larger and larger bodies of knowledge," she writes. Yet schools continue to treat students as empty glasses into which information can be poured — and public officials continue to judge schools on the basis of how efficiently and determinedly they pour.

3. Students are more likely to learn what they find interesting.

There's no shortage of evidence for this claim if you really need it. One of many examples: A group of researchers found that children's level of interest in a passage they were reading was 30 times more useful than its difficulty level for predicting how much of it they would later remember. But this should be obvious, if only because of what we know about ourselves. It's the tasks that intrigue us, that tap our curiosity and con-

nect to the things we care about, that we tend to keep doing — and get better at doing. So, too, for kids.

Conversely, students are less likely to benefit from doing what they hate. Psychology has come a long way from the days when theorists tried to reduce everything to simple stimulus-response pairings. We know now that people aren't machines, such that an input (listening to a lecture, reading a textbook, filling out a worksheet) will reliably yield an output (learning). What matters is how people experience what they do, what meaning they ascribe to it, what their attitudes and goals are.

Thus, if students find an academic task stressful or boring, they're far less likely to understand, or even remember, the content. And if they're uninterested in a whole category of academic tasks — say, those they're assigned to do when they get home after having just spent a whole day at school — then they aren't likely to benefit much from doing them. No wonder research finds little, if any, advantage to assigning homework, particularly in elementary or middle school.

4. Students are less interested in whatever they're forced to do and more enthusiastic when they have some say.

Once again, studies confirm what we already know from experience. The nearly universal negative reaction to compulsion, like the positive response to choice, is a function of our psychological makeup.

Now combine this point with the preceding one: If choice is related to interest, and interest is related to achievement, then it's not much of a stretch to suggest that the learning environments in which kids get to make decisions about what they're doing are likely to be the most effective, all else being equal. Yet, such learning environments continue to be vastly outnumbered by those where kids spend most of their time just following directions.

5. Just because doing x raises standardized test scores doesn't mean x should be done.

At the very least, we would need evidence that the test in question is a source of useful information about

Waste-Free Lunches for Earth Day and Every Day

by Amy Hemmert

According to the New York State Department of Conservation, a child taking a disposable lunch to school will create an average of 67 pounds of trash per school year — a pretty heavy load for schools to haul off to landfills and incinerators.

In an effort to address this growing problem, teachers, parents, administrators, and students are working together to implement waste-free lunch programs. And here's what they recommend:

- ✓ **Make it a habit.** It's easy once you make waste-free lunches part of your daily routine.
- ✓ **Pack food in reusable containers.** Avoid plastic bags, plastic wrap, aluminum foil, and prepackaged foods whenever possible.



- ✓ **Use a refillable drink bottle** instead of disposables.
- ✓ **Use a cloth napkin** instead of paper
- ✓ **Pack reusable utensils** instead of disposables.

Packing a waste-free lunch may take a bit more time and creativity but, given the environmental benefits, it's well worth the extra effort. Here are some tips for making it work:

whether our teaching and learning goals are being met. Many educators have argued that the tests being used in our schools are unsatisfactory for several reasons.

First, there are numerous limitations with specific tests. Second, most tests share certain problematic features, such as being timed (which places more of a premium on speed than on thoughtfulness), norm-referenced (which means the tests are designed to tell us who's beating whom, not how well students have learned or teachers have taught), and consisting largely of multiple-choice questions (which don't permit students to generate or even explain their answers).

The third reason is the problems inherent to all tests that are standardized and created by people far away from the classroom — as opposed to assessing the actual learning taking place there on an on-going basis.

This is not the place to explain in detail why standardized tests measure what matters least. Here, I want only to make the simpler — and, once again, I think, indisputable — point that anyone who

regards high or rising test scores as good news has an obligation to show that the tests themselves are good. If a test result can't be convincingly shown to be both valid and meaningful, then whatever we did to achieve that result — say, a new curriculum or instructional strategy — may well have no merit whatsoever. It may even prove to be destructive when assessed by better criteria. Indeed, a school or district might be getting worse even as its test scores rise.

So how is it that articles in newspapers and education journals, as well as pronouncements by public officials and think tanks, seem to accept on faith that better scores on any test necessarily constitute good news, and that whatever produced those scores can be described as 'effective'? Parents should be encouraged to ask: *How much time was sacrificed from real learning just so our kids could get better at taking the [name of test]?*

6. Students are more likely to succeed in a place where they feel known and cared about.

I realize there are people whose impulse is to sneer when talk turns to how kids feel, and who dismiss as 'soft' or 'faddish'

anything other than old-fashioned instruction of academic skills. But even these hard-liners, when pressed, are unable to deny the relationship between feeling and thinking, between a child's comfort level and his or her capacity to learn.

Here, too, there are loads of supporting data. As one group of researchers put it, "In order to promote students' academic performance in the classroom, educators should also promote their social and emotional adjustment." And yet, broadly speaking, we don't. Teachers and schools are evaluated almost exclusively on academic achievement measures (which, to make matters worse, mostly consist of standardized test scores).

If we took seriously the need for kids to feel known and cared about, our discussions about the distinguishing features of a 'good school' would sound very different. Likewise, our view of discipline and classroom management would be turned inside-out, seeing as how the primary goals of most such strategies are obedience and order, often with the re-



- Pack lunches the night before and store them in the refrigerator overnight.
- Maximize leftovers. Prepare extra servings at dinnertime for the next day's lunches. Pack the leftovers in lunchboxes in the evening when you're doing your regular dinner clean up.
- Keep fresh fruits, vegetables, whole grains, and other nutritious foods on hand.
- Keep nuts and dried fruit on hand for emergencies.
- Buy from bulk bins to reduce your costs.
- Consider purchasing a CSA (Community Supported Agriculture) share or shop at the farmers' market.
- Write your name on all your containers before you leave the house.

Talk to students, parents, and teachers about waste-free lunches. Post signs in the lunch area and send informative notes home to families. Get students, parents, teachers, and administrators in-

involved. If possible, schedule a field trip to the landfill or recycling facility so students can see where their trash goes.

Perform a trash audit to find out what's in your trash. Is your trash made up of mostly food waste or packaging waste? Does it contain compostables or recyclables? If so, how can these be diverted? Is the bulk of the trash coming from home or from the school lunch program? What changes will help reduce waste?

Start a waste-free lunch program at your school. For details, visit www.wastefreelunches.org.

Save money with waste-free lunches. Packing a waste-free lunch not only reduces landfill waste, but it costs less too. A prepackaged lunch costs about \$4.02 a day or \$723.60 per school year compared to \$2.65 a day (\$477.00 per school year) for a waste-free lunch—a difference of \$246.60 per person per year.

Help your school save money. Waste-free lunch programs help schools re-

duce waste hauling fees by reducing the amount of trash they send to the landfill. The savings can be spent in the classroom, landfills last longer, and children learn the importance of protecting the planet — three good reasons to pack a waste-free lunch this Earth Day and every day!

For more information on waste-free lunches, to find out what others are doing, or to share your own waste-free lunch story, visit www.wastefreelunches.org.

Amy Hemmert, president and co-founder of **Obentec, Inc** (www.laptoplunches.com) is a writer, educator, and mother of two. She holds a bachelor's degree in biology and a master's degree in English. She has co-authored five books and numerous articles, and has been a frequent presenter at professional conferences in the US and abroad. Her interests include cross-cultural communication, language acquisition, family nutrition, organic gardening, cooking, yoga, and environmental studies.

sult that kids feel less cared about — or even bullied — by adults.

7. We want children to develop in many ways, not just academically.

Even mainstream education groups have embraced the idea of teaching the ‘whole child.’ It’s a safe position, really, because just about every parent or educator will tell you that we should be supporting children’s physical, emotional, social, moral, and artistic growth as well as their intellectual growth. Moreover, it’s obvious to most people that the schools can, and should, play a key role in promoting many different forms of development.

If we acknowledge that academics is just one facet of a good education, why do so few conversations about improving our schools deal with — and why are so few resources devoted to — non-academic issues? And why do we assign children still more academic tasks after the school day is over, even when those tasks cut into the time children have to pursue interests that will help them develop in other ways?

Corollary 7a: Students “learn best when they are happy,” as educator Nel Noddings reminded us, but that doesn’t mean they’re especially likely to be happy (or psychologically healthy) just because they’re academically successful. And millions aren’t. Imagine how high schools would have to be changed if we were to take this realization seriously.

8. Just because a lesson (or book, or class, or test) is harder doesn’t mean it’s better.

First, if it’s pointless to give students things to do that are too easy, it’s also counterproductive to give them things that they experience as too hard. Second, and more important, this criterion overlooks a variety of considerations other than difficulty level by which educational quality might be evaluated.

We know this, yet we continue to worship at the altar of ‘rigor.’ I’ve seen lessons that aren’t unduly challenging yet are deeply engaging and intellectually valuable. Conversely, I’ve seen courses — and whole schools — that are indisputably rigorous . . . and appallingly bad.

9. Kids aren’t just short adults.

Over the past hundred years, developmental psychologists have labored to describe what makes children distinctive and what they can understand at certain ages. There are limits, after all, to what even a precocious younger child can grasp (e.g., the way metaphors function, the significance of making a promise) or do (e.g., keep still for an extended period).

Likewise, there are certain things children require for optimal development, including opportunities to play and explore, alone and with others. Research fills in — and keeps fine-tuning — the details, but the fundamental implication isn’t hard to grasp: How we educate kids should follow from what defines them as kids.

Somehow, though, developmentally inappropriate education has become the norm, as kindergarten (literally, the “children’s garden”) now tends to resemble a first- or second-grade classroom — in fact, a bad first- or second-grade classroom, where discovery, creativity, and social interaction are replaced by a repetitive regimen focused on narrowly defined academic skills.

More generally, premature exposure to sit-still-and-listen instruction, homework, grades, tests, and competition — practices that are clearly a bad match for younger children and of questionable value at any age — is rationalized by invoking a notion I’ve called BGUTI:

Better Get Used To It. The logic here is that we have to prepare you for the bad things that are going to be done to you later . . . by doing them to you now. When articulated explicitly, that principle sounds exactly as ridiculous as it is. Nevertheless, it’s the engine that continues to drive an awful lot of nonsense.

The obvious premise that we should respect what makes children children can be amended to include a related principle that is less obvious to some people: Learning something earlier isn’t necessarily better. Deborah Meier, whose experience as a celebrated educator ranges from kindergarten to high school, put it bluntly: “The earlier [that schools try] to inculcate so-called ‘academic’ skills, the deeper the damage and the more permanent the ‘achievement’ gap.” That is exactly what a passel of ambitious research projects has found: A traditional

skills-based approach to teaching young children — particularly those from low-income families — not only offers no lasting benefits but appears to be harmful.

Corollary 9A: Kids aren’t just future adults. They are that, of course, but they aren’t only that, because children’s needs and perspectives are worth attending to in their own right. We violate this precept — and do a disservice to children — whenever we talk about schooling in economic terms, treating students mostly as future employees.

10. Substance matters more than labels.

A skunk cabbage by any other name would smell just as putrid. But in education, as in other domains, we’re often seduced by appealing names when we should be demanding to know exactly what lies behind them. Most of us, for example, favor a sense of community, prefer that a job be done by professionals, and want to promote learning. So should we sign on to the work being done in the name of Professional Learning Communities? Not if it turns out that PLCs have less to do with helping children to think deeply about questions that matter than with boosting standardized test scores.

The same caution is appropriate when it comes to Positive Behavior Support, a jaunty moniker for a program of crude Skinnerian manipulation in which students are essentially bribed to do whatever they’re told. More broadly, even the label “school reform” doesn’t necessarily signify improvement; these days, it’s more likely to mean “something that skillful and caring teachers wouldn’t be inclined to do unless coerced,” as educational psychologist Bruce Marlowe put it.

In fact, the corporate-style version of ‘school reform’ that’s uncritically endorsed these days by politicians, journalists, and billionaires consists of a series of debatable tactics — many of them amounting to bribes and threats to force educators to jack up test scores. Just as worrisome, though, is that these reformers often overlook, or simply violate, a number of propositions that aren’t debatable, including many of those listed here. ♦

First Impressions: Impressionistic Lessons Using Grammar Symbols In the Lower Elementary Classroom

by Debbie Vale

Lower Elementary Guide

The NewGate School, Sarasota, FL

<http://helpfromdebbie.blogspot.com>

We all know the importance of making a good first impression. In the world of Montessori, there are presentations that fall into the category of Impressionistic Lessons. These lessons are designed to make a deep and lasting impression on the students. These lessons have impact and ignite the student's imagination.

One of the materials that often catches the eye of students and parents are the grammar symbols. A set of the three dimensional shapes holds mystery and wonder. Children and parents are curious about what these different geometric solids represent and how they are used in lessons.

It is well known that the materials in a Montessori environment are designed to inspire children to learn more about them. This visual arouses curiosity. So when a teacher is ready to present a grammar symbol to her students, they are often eager to hear her story and discover what the symbol represents.

As a teacher, I treat these Impressionistic Lessons with reverence and try to create an atmosphere of anticipation so that the child is ready to absorb the presentation. It is helpful to make the stories of these symbols your own. The stories of the word functions may differ from teacher to teacher, but I believe the presentations should be simple, brief, and memorable. It is the ambiance that is created during the stories that engages the students. I tell the stories as if I am letting the students in on a secret.

The Noun

I place the three-dimensional symbol in the center of the work rug. The students gather and I tell the story.

When you were a baby, you learned how to speak. The first words you probably used were words that named things. *Mama*, *Dada*, and *blankie* might have been some of your first words. When humans first began to speak, the first words they used were naming words too. *Food*, *fire*, and *baby* might have been some of the words they used. Even though these people lived a very long time ago, the words they used to name the things in the world still exist. People have names for everything.

Naming words are very special. They are solid and stable. They represent the *things* in our world. We



Above: These students are practicing prepositions. The boy is under the chair. He holds up the word under to show his position in relation to the chair.

use this black pyramid to represent these words in our language. We use a pyramid because it is very old and very stable with a wide base, we use the color black because carbon is a very old scientific element and it has a black color. Black also seems solid and stable.

There is a special name for these naming words. They are called *nouns*, and nouns are the names of the people, places, and things in our world. The word *noun* actually means *name*.

Although the story seems simple, it is enough to inspire the children to label all the nouns they can find in the classroom, to make lists of the nouns they see on the way to school, and to symbolize the nouns in their sentences.

The Article

I place the noun and the article three dimensional symbols in the center of the work rug along with a pencil, two erasers, and a few beads. The students gather around, as I introduce the article.

We have been finding nouns all around us and even in our sentences and stories. Have you noticed that there are other types of words as well? Different words have different jobs. There are three words that have an important job.

Please hand me *the* pencil. I take the pencil and put a label reading "the pencil" next to it. Please hand me *a* bead. I take the bead and put the label reading "a bead" next to it. Please hand me *an* eraser. I take the eraser and put a label reading "an eraser" next to it.

I take the noun symbol and place it over above the nouns.

We know these words are nouns. These other words are not nouns. Their job is to point out that a noun will be coming soon. We call them *articles*. In our language there are only three. Some languages have many more and some have none at all.

We use a small pyramid because the article is part of the noun family and will always announce that a noun will soon appear. The name *article* comes from Latin and means *a small part or a member*. The article is a small part or member of the noun family. Although it is small, it is important.

The Adjective

I place the two symbols we have been practicing plus the adjective symbol in the center of the rug.

We have been practicing nouns and articles, and it is time to learn a new symbol.

Please bring me a pencil. (*The child gets the pencil.*) Thank you but that is not the one I want.

I ask another child to please bring me a pencil. "Thank you but that is not the one I want." I ask a third child to please bring me a red pencil. (Or another color, if a red one has already been brought to the rug.)

It was challenging to find the pencil I wanted because I didn't add any other words to the word *pencil*.

Our next grammar symbol represents the words we use to describe the noun. They can be colors, numbers, or many other describing words such as *cold*, *hot*, *heavy*, *light*, *full*, and *empty*.

We use a medium dark blue pyramid, because this word is a part of the noun family and always stands between the article and the noun. Sometimes there is more than one between the article and the noun such as: "The new red pencil."

This type of word has a special name, it is called an *adjective* and means *to add to*. We add it to the noun to describe or tell us something about the noun. Let's see if we can find any adjectives in our other work today.

The Verb

I have a list of cards on the rug. Written in black are words such as *map*, *cup*,

book, and *bead*. Written in red are words such as *jump*, *clap*, *smile*, and *walk*.

Please bring me a *map*.

The student brings a map, and we put the label next to it. This continues with the other nouns.

Now please bring me *jump*.

The children usually get up and jump. That is a good demonstration of how to jump, but we cannot put that here on the rug next to the label.

Please bring me *clap*.

They clap. That is a good demonstration of how to clap but we cannot put it here next to the label.

Please bring me *smile* and put it next to the label.

They tend to think about this but realize they cannot do this.

Can you bring me *walk* and put it here next to the label?

They answer *no*.

Do you remember what type of words these are (*pointing to the nouns*)?

They say *nouns*.

The words on this side are different. They are things you can do. They have movement and energy.

I take out the noun symbol and the verb symbols.

Remember that the noun is solid and stable; when I push on it it does not go very far. But watch what happens when I push this symbol. It goes very far and has energy to move freely in any direction. We use a red sphere to represent this word, because red is the color of fire, which has energy, and a sphere is the shape of the sun, which gives us energy.

This type of word is called a *verb*. It comes from Latin and means *word par excellence*, the most important word in the sentence.

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The Preposition

I hand each student a gumdrop or life-saver.

We are going to use these candies to learn a new type of word. I am going to give directions. I want you to follow them and tell me the position of the gumdrop.

Put the gumdrop over your head.
What is the position of the gumdrop?

They answer *over*.

Put the gumdrop behind you,
what is the position? *Behind*.

Put the gumdrop under your chin,
what is the position? *Under*.

Carry the gumdrop across the
room, what is the position? *Across*.

This can go on for a while until we get to the following command:

Put the gumdrop in your mouth,
what is the position? *In*.

I show the students the symbol. We use a green bridge to represent this type of word. It tells us our position. We can be *on* the bridge, *under* it, *next* to it, *be-bind* it or *in front* of it.

We call this word a *preposition*. It comes from Latin and means *before*, we place it before the second noun in the sentence. It shows a relationship between two nouns. A preposition tells the position.

Note: I have also done this lesson relating the student to his or her chair. They enjoy standing on the chair and crawling under the chair.

The Adverb

I have verbs written in red and adverbs written in orange. I place the verb and the adverb symbols on the rug.

Here is another symbol that represents a word that can move freely. As a matter of fact, it moves around the verb just as our planet moves around the sun. Let's try it.

This word is *walk*, it is a verb. I am going to add this word, *slowly* to *walk*. Now walk *slowly*.



Left: In the next group, these students are practicing prepositions. Emma gives the pencil to Koy, which becomes: "She gives the pencil to him." Wearing the purple hats reminds them that the pronoun's job is important. The pronoun takes the place of the noun.

After the child does this, I ask another child to "slowly walk." Does the activity change? No. Does the word order change? Yes.

We continue with *clap softly*, *softly clap*, *bop silently*, *silently bop*, *breathe deeply*, and *deeply breathe*.

These words are added to the verb to tell us how to perform the action. They are called *adverbs*.

I lay the words on the rug next to each other and under the proper symbol. If students do not notice that the adverbs end in *ly*, I will ask if they can find something similar about the adverbs, and they usually do. If they do not notice, I may say, "As we work with these words, you may notice something many adverbs have in common. When you think you know what it is, come and whisper it to me."

If they do notice, I will say, "It is true that many adverbs end in *ly*, but some do not."

The Pronoun

I have hats that I make out of purple construction paper by forming a cone. Each hat has a word on it: *I*, *me*, *we*, *us*, *he*, *him*, *she*, *her*, *they*, *them*.

I have made these hats for you. We will use them in our lesson. I will say a sentence and then we will wear the hats, and someone else will say the sentence, but they will change the words.

Mary gives the pencil to Bob.

Mary and Bob please stand up and wear these hats.

I will put the hat that says *she* on Mary and the hat that says *him* on Bob.

Now let's say the sentence. (*She gives the pencil to him*.)

Jack reads a book to the class. I give Jack the hat that says *he*.

Let's put the hat that says *us* in the middle of the circle to represent all of us. The new sentence is: "He reads the book to us."

We continue until we have used all the hats.

These words have a very important job. They take the place of the noun. They stand tall and proud, they are purple. (*I show the symbol*.) They are called *pronouns* which means *in place of the noun*.

Note: The students like to take the hats and wear them for the rest of the day!



Above: Students are practicing adverbs and their placement. The adverb tells us how to perform the verb, it can come before or after the verb. *Clap softly* is the same action as *softly clap*. *Jump quickly* is the same action as *quickly jump*. *Sleep quietly* is the same action as *quietly sleep*. The students move the adverb around the verb as if it is a planet orbiting the sun.

The Conjunction

I prepare strips of pink paper with the words, "Come join me for a lesson." I have a vase of different colored flowers and cut pink ribbons ready on the work rug.

I asked you to come join me at this lesson. I am going to give you the white flower *and* the yellow flower. Please join them together with this pink ribbon.

To a different student, I say, "Would you like *either* the red flower *or* the orange flower? Please tie the pink ribbon around the red flower *or* the orange flower." To the third student, I say, "There is only one flower left, *so* this one is for you. Please tie a pink ribbon around it." I take out labels with the words, *and*, *either*, *or*, and *so* and lay them on the rug.

These words join other words or phrases together. We call them *conjunctions* which is Latin and means *join with*. We use this pink rectangle to remind us of the pink ribbon that is joining our flowers together. Let's see how many we can find in our work today.

Note: Some students say that the pink rectangle reminds them of a piece of bubble gum, I tell them that is another good way to remember it because gum is sticky, and it can join things together by being sticky.

The Interjection

I use a plastic baseball bat to represent a club in this lesson.

I want to tell you a story that happened many many years ago, when people lived in caves and had to go out to hunt for food.

One night, a man took his club and told his family he was going to find some dinner. After being gone for hours he came home all tired and worn out. His family was waiting for him. They said, "Dad is home, where's the food?"

Dad replied, "Oh! No food tonight."

The next night, Dad went out again. He came home hours later. He was tired. The family was waiting and asked, "Is there any food?"

Dad replied, "Ugh! No food tonight."

The third night Dad went out again. It was rainy. He was gone a long time. The family didn't ask Dad about the food.

Dad put some meat on the table and said, "Hurray! Tonight we eat!" (*I hold the club up so it looks like an exclamation point.*)

The family cheered. "Yippee!" "Yahoo!" "Yeah!" and Dad was a happy man.

I have labels prepared with all of the interjections I used in the story.

We throw words like these into sentences to give them excitement. The sentence will still be fine without it, but it is more interesting with words like these. They add feeling. We call them *interjections* from Latin which means *to throw something into*. We throw these words into sentences to express our emotions.

Another way to look at this symbol is that the interjection is the key to the emotion in the sentence. The symbol can be seen as a keyhole.

I allow plenty of time to practice each word and its function. Using the grammar boxes and letting students analyze and symbolize text help students recognize each type of word. Using sentence strips and grammar games allow students to recall and come up with words in the proper context. Allowing students to create their own grammar games and sentence strips shows proficiency and is also a lot of fun. ♦



Gift Giving

by Margot
Garfield-Anderson

Director of Public Relations
The Montessori Foundation

Plucky Jayne, the grandchild I so often write about, turned two the end of March. What a wonderful blur these years have been, watching and observing her growth and development. She's a sweet, funny, introspective and very verbal child with an old soul. She's very observant, concentrates for long periods of time, and delights in all things children her age delight in.

As the parents or grandparents of a small child, our inclination is to use our buying power to purchase every single thing under the sun. As Montessori parents and grandparents, I urge you to control this impulse. Just as children in Montessori schools and environments do not have a lot of 'stuff' surrounding them, thus encouraging them to use each item they do have

access to thoroughly until they gain focus, concentration, attention span and mastery, use that same logic when buying or giving presents.

For Blakely's birthday, I purchased a beautiful wooden lady bug puzzle made by Hello Wood Products. It's simple yet age appropriate, with knobs, four lady bugs (in descending size order), and very durable. This item will allow her small hands to use her pincer grip on the knobs and help her begin to work with the concepts of *big* to *small* and reading left to right. It may not sing a mechanical song every time she does something correctly or yell out, *Good Job*, but it has the built-in control of error we use in all didactic material; it's portable, interesting, beautiful, and well made.

At the tender age of two, she will not balk that she didn't receive some plastic toy-of-the-month item. She will delight in this one item which is significant to us as her nickname is "Lady Bug." The present has meaning for us, and I love that she gets the connection even at this age.

Another gift I have given her was a pair of socks decorated with flamingoes. OK, it's *kitsch*, but I live in Southwest Florida, where we actually have flamingos in our Jungle Gardens, and I have some tasteful flamingo collectibles in my house that we talk about when she visits. We were doing a Facetime™ talk the other night and she said, "Grammy, my socks." She was wearing her pair and, even though it has been weeks since we've seen each other, she made the connection. That is a better than seeing her play mindlessly with a plastic toy that she discards after a short time. Building those memories is what really counts.

Of course, the gift of your time can't be measured in dollars, but the payback is huge. We love to sit on our back lanai and just blow bubbles. Chasing the bubbles, trying to make her mouth blow so she gets a few out, and then just watching her, knowing she loves this small activity together provides us with hours of quality time.

Other great gift items to share with your child would be memberships to your local YMCA or JCC. Blakely's other grandmother lives closer. She takes her for swim lessons once a week. What an incredible bond of trust she's helped forge with her and what a wonderfully important practical life skill this will be for Blakely, whose parents happen to have a built in swimming pool in their yard.

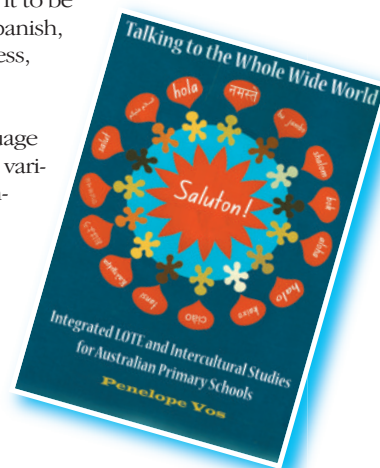
Should your town or city have a hands-on museum or science center, memberships here are often affordable and provide lots of exploration scenarios for the young child while allowing them some room to move. Again, the point is you don't have to spend a fortune, buy into consumerism, or load the child up with items that do not really stimulate their creativity or foster a skill to give them gifts for special occasions. ♦

10 Reasons to Be Delighted that Your Child is Learning Esperanto

by Penelope Vos

Esperanto is the most widely spoken constructed international auxiliary language.[1] Its name derives from Doktoro Esperanto (Esperanto translates as 'one who hopes'), the pseudonym under which L. L. Zamenhof published the first book detailing Esperanto, the *Unua Libro*, in 1887. Zamenhof's goal was to create an easy-to-learn and politically neutral language that transcends nationality and would foster peace and international understanding between people with different regional and/or national languages. <http://en.wikipedia.org>

- 1 The design of Esperanto enables it to be learned six times quicker than Spanish, giving your child sense of progress, achievement and confidence.
- 2 Esperanto is a whole world language and fosters interest in the widest variety of other cultures and environments.
- 3 Mastery of Esperanto speeds the learning of subsequent languages, because of transferrable learning about how languages work, and how to learn them, and through increased confidence and motivation.
- 4 If your school is teaching Esperanto, your teachers are clearly not stuck in a rut! They are learning and thinking and looking for ways to responsibly provide indirect preparation opportunities in your child's learning environment. Celebrate! You chose Montessori for such diligence.
- 5 Esperanto is a living example of human creativity, wisdom and courage. It was designed, over a lifetime, to be a win-win solution to the problem of achieving effective and respectful intercultural communication, whilst recognizing that all people need time to maintain their own languages and culture, which comprise a large part of their identity. Part of education is to expose children to examples of heroism and solid values, to help them find their own greatness.
- 6 Esperanto supports formal learning of English because it has "transparent" grammar. This means that nouns, adjectives, six varieties of verbs, adverbs and pronouns are all easily recognizable by the last letter(s). As one child said recently, "I know if a word is an adjective by whether it ends with an *a* in Esperanto."
- 7 High order thinking skills need practice to become habitual. Because Esperanto has only 28 sounds and symbols, 16 grammar rules with no exceptions, and word-building units that are always applicable and constant, there is much less random stuff to remember, which leaves more time to practice understanding, application, analysis, evaluation and creativity.



continued on page 36



by
Cathleen
Haskins



The Montessori Environment: The structure that allows young child to develop normally and successfully self-educate

Part 4

Cathleen currently resides in beautiful Door County, Wisconsin. She is a certified Montessori teacher with private and public Montessori School experience, and currently works full time as a freelance writer, speaker, and workshop facilitator, supporting and prompting Montessori Education. To read her blog and learn more about her work go to: <http://www.montessoriwise.com>. Contact her at cathleen@montessoriwise.com

This is the fourth and final article in the series *Explaining the Extraordinary*, in which we have been exploring the following questions in order to better understand and communicate what Montessori education is and how it works.

- What is the primary goal of Montessori education?
- What is the fundamental process through which the goal is attained?
- What is the essential principle that allows the process to occur?
- What is the structure that enables the child to successfully navigate the process?

In the first article, we explored the primary goal of Montessori education, which is to nurture and support the unfolding of a child's potential. In Part 2 of this series, we examined the concept of normalization as the natural process that allows human potential to develop, and in Part 3, we explored liberty as the essential principle which is necessary if the child is to develop naturally (normally). Some unknowing folks might mistakenly assume that a learning environment that embraces freedom and natural development would be chaotic, disorganized, and noisy. But this is not the case. In this final article, we will look at the Montessori Prepared Environment, the structure that allows the young child to develop normally and successfully self-educate in order that her full potential be cultivated and made visible.



"The child alone can reveal the plan that is natural to man. But because of its delicate condition, like that of all incipient beings, the psychic life of a child needs to be surrounded by an environment that could be compared with the wrappings placed by nature about the physical embryo."

In conventional early childhood education, the teacher is the hub of the classroom. All things evolve around her. Assigned desks and worktables in early elementary classrooms support the teacher in her efforts to be in control at all times. She leads lessons by standing

in front of the room, while the children are required to sit still and give their full attention to her as she speaks, reads, and designates when they may get up from their desks, speak, use the restroom, and move to the next subject. But in Montessori classrooms children have many choices about the work they will do. It is common in a class of 25 students to have somewhere between 15 to 20 different things going on at any given moment during morning work time.

There are usually no assigned desks or tables, and the children are at liberty to decide for themselves where to work. Sometimes, they work alone on a work rug, and at other times they work with another child at a table. There is no scheduled time for science, math, or language. Each child chooses when and how long he will work on a subject.

One child may spend an hour on a math activity, while another child will spend 30 minutes engaged in the same activity. One could easily imagine that, in a room of 3-6 year-old children or 6-9 year-old students, this could result in chaos. But it does not. In fact, it can run quite smoothly and peacefully with free children engaged in purposeful work.

How does it work? The answer lies with the Prepared Environment.

The success of children in Montessori schools rests upon the Prepared Environment, which serves as the central axis; the classroom is designed and maintained with full attention given to the smallest detail. It is the Prepared Environment that keeps the Montessori classroom from becoming a free-for-all den of disorderliness and frenetic, purposeless activity. The teacher gives extensive time and effort to the Prepared Environment, because it serves as the structure in which spontaneous, self-learning experiences can occur. The intellectual success and spiritual growth

Some unknowing folks might mistakenly assume that a learning environment that embraces freedom and natural development would be chaotic, disorganized, and noisy.

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of the child is intimately linked to the preparation of his classroom. As part of traditional pre-service training, future teachers study classroom management. In Montessori training centers, classroom management is in large part contingent on the Prepared Environment. Rather than implementing strategies to 'manage' the children, rewards to bribe, or punishments to threaten, the focus turns to the Prepared Environment. The Prepared Environment is the supporting structure that protects and nourishes a child's potential. A child that is managed by an adult is not free to self-educate, develop self-discipline, or grow normally, yet all of these are necessary to nurture human potential. Let's explore the specific characteristics of the Prepared Environment.

Order, Organization, and Accessibility

Maria Montessori observed that very early in life young children desire and thrive in an orderly and organized environment. As in Montessori's day, most adults today generally do not consider that children have an innate desire for

order. Instead, children are accused of being inherently messy, an idea Montessori refuted, claiming a natural sensitive period for order during early childhood. "A proper environment for the soul," she wrote, "is one in which an individual can move about with eyes closed and find, simply by reaching out his hand, anything he desires. Such an environment is necessary for peace and happiness."

Therefore, Montessori insisted upon uncluttered learning environments in which furniture was carefully arranged and the materials and activities meticulously displayed and maintained. In such a consistent and orderly environment, the child can depend on finding any given material in its place, and she will know where to return things when she has finished using them. Having the classroom materials organized and accessible encourages independence and self-reliance, for there is no need to ask the teacher where a particular item is located, nor is the child dependent upon an adult to pull out of cabinets or from high shelves the items she desires.

If a child is not working at a table, she is on the floor using a work rug, which defines her workspace and helps in the organization of the materials being used. Learning to keep all materials orderly and within reach on the work area – organizing color pencils and writing utensils in a small container, arranging papers and books neatly rather than allowing the work materials to sprawl across the floor or table – are all part of Early Childhood and Elementary Montessori learning experiences.

Beauty and Simplicity

Human beings need and long for beauty. Beauty inspires us, connects us to the present moment and soothes our soul. Yet the connection between learning environments and beauty often seems lost in conventional early childhood classrooms, which commonly lack aesthetic design, are overwhelmed with plastic toys, and dominated by bright primary colors and animated posters plastering the walls.

In the best Montessori environments, beauty is an obvious component; the materials themselves are designed to be beautiful in ways that invite the child to explore and to encourage careful handling and respectful use. In fact, the materials are made to be beautiful so that they may call to the child: *choose me, use me with gentle-*

ness and care, put me back as you found me.

The Practical Life materials, for example, are not simply well-organized, they are intentionally put together to look attractive to the child. A pouring activity may consist of a brilliant blue depression-era type pitcher with four matching glasses set on a lovely ceramic tray. I once visited an elementary classroom in which three of the solid blue math prisms, ranging from 8 - 12 inches tall, were simply placed on a black shelf mounted on the wall. It looked like a piece of art.

Parents should expect to find elements of beauty in their child's classroom, though it will take many different forms. Simplicity and beauty in the classroom go hand-in-hand, evoking interest and inspiration in the materials, and supporting independent activity and auto-education.

Reality-Based Furnishings

In a traditional preschool setting, one would commonly see a play kitchen area equipped with a toy refrigerator, stove, sink, and cupboard stocked with plastic food. In a Montessori environment, you would find none of these, but you would very likely find a working, small-size refrigerator, a real sink, and real food-prep utensils. These are not toys; they are functioning household tools, sized for use by young children.

Current early childhood theorists insist that children would rather play than do anything else, but the value and preference for work is evident when one sees the joy, pride, independence, and sense of self that Montessori children experience when engaged in purposeful work activity. They earnestly desire to scrub the floor, wash tables, dust furniture, clean windows, make their own snacks, sharpen color pencils, hoe in the garden, and create flower arrangements for the tables or shelves. This is real and purposeful work for them, and, therefore, the environment contains real and functional materials with which they can respond with grace and dignity to the tasks that they feel called to carry out.

Specifically Designed Learning Materials

A visitor could walk into a dozen different Montessori Early Childhood classrooms and find the same math materi-

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als, wooden continent maps, and Pink Tower material. Dr. Montessori was a forerunner in her advocacy for active learning and concrete materials, insisting that the child learns best when she engages her hand and her mind together. She also understood that if a child is to self-educate as part of the normal process of growth, then the materials would need to be self-correcting. If the child could be free from an adult's constant corrections and criticisms, he could not only be more responsible for his own learning, but could do so with dignity and self-respect.

The Montessori materials provide a logical series of objectives connected in a developmental sequence. This is particularly evident in the sensorial, practical life, and math materials, where each activity serves a purpose that is intimately connected to the prior and subsequent material. How the materials connect across content areas is also obvious, as in the Elementary Cosmic Education curriculum, which aids the students in understanding the interconnectedness of biology, zoology, botany, geography, and history.

The didactic materials are an important part of the Montessori classroom; they are beautiful and simple in their appeal in order to attract the attention of the child. They should be clean, all pieces intact, and show signs of being well cared for and maintained, even as they age. The materials are treated with great care, which fosters a sense of stewardship and respect for one's belongings, certainly an important message that counters the pervasive 'throw-away' attitude that has permeated western society for decades.

Three-Year Age Span

As a former elementary teacher, I can attest to the tremendous value of a three-year, multiage classroom. It allows for knowing the children on a deep and personal level, for providing rich relationship experiences, and for building a strong sense of community. The multiage environment provides the younger students ongoing opportunities to observe, interact with, and learn from the older children in the classroom, while giving older children a chance to be mentors and models, building self-confidence and leadership qualities from a young age.

Being in the same classroom for three years gives children a solid grounding in their environment. They

know it well. They know the other children intimately.

They participate and look forward to annual events, traditions, and rituals that provide a sense of continuity and belonging. The three-year, multi-age learning environment is an authentic first experience in learning to live respectfully and compassionately in community with others. It provides opportunities and experiences that single age classrooms simply cannot offer.

Access to the Outdoors

In the best situations, Montessori classrooms have access to the outdoors, as nature is considered a direct extension of the learning environment. In Montessori schools around the world, you are apt to find a door that leads to beautiful gardens and outdoor spaces for the children to enjoy or to busy themselves with planting, tending, and harvesting. There are benches on which a child can sit and rest in the sunshine. Here the children observe toads hidden among the plants, birds singing and calling, and spiders spinning webs. In warm weather children may carry small tables out to work in the fresh air, or to enjoy their snack among the butterflies and grasshoppers.

Montessori envisioned children freely moving between the indoor and the outdoor environment for she understood that being in nature is nourishment for the soul. In some of the earliest photos of the first Montessori schools, we see children enjoying lunch in the open air, napping on small cots, writing on the terrace, and engaging with the learning materials on their work rugs in the garden. This connection between the indoor and outdoor environment nourishes a love and respect for nature and firmly roots children in experiences in the natural world.

Strong Sense of Community and Peace

The Montessori classroom plants the seeds for learning how to live and work together in a peaceful community. Respect, kindness, compassion, and peace are a conscious and deliberate focus. Traditional schools rely heavily on classroom management techniques implemented by the teacher; Montessori schools aspire to build respectful and loving communities in which children learn at a young age how to work

through conflicts, affirm each other, and be seekers of goodness. These are places that allow and encourage children to take responsibility for the peaceful functioning of their classroom community.

The classroom community in Montessori schools rests on a foundation of respect for self, others, and the environment. Respect is fundamental, but it alone does not account for the peaceful, caring environments that astonish those who come to visit.

Teachers consciously endeavor to read books, tell stories, and integrate activities that cultivate compassion, kindness, and peace. Some classrooms have peace materials and activities on a peace shelf; others have a peace table or corner and some designate a special part of the day for inner peace. There are service projects, community volunteerism, and celebrations of cultures around the world. In fact, the heart of the Elementary Montessori curriculum, Cosmic Education, promotes a sense of grandeur, awe, and gratitude for the natural world while helping children at a young age understand that every life has purpose and value.

Conclusion

The goal of Montessori education is to nurture and reveal the child's potential. There is a process through which every child's potential is unveiled, a process Maria Montessori referred to as "normal development," meaning the child is free of the obstacles which can so easily disparage and repress the unfolding of her potential. But the child cannot develop normally unless she is free. There must be liberty for the child. She must be free so that she can hear and respond to the inner directives and constructive instincts that guide and inspire her normal development.

When the child is free, the role of the adult changes dramatically. He must step down from his pillar of authority and give up his central position in the classroom, putting his energies instead into the creation and maintenance of a Prepared Environment which will support the child as she directs the unfolding of her own self and potential.

The Prepared Environment is the structure which allows the child to function successfully as an independent, free being, developing normally in order that her full potential be cultivated. ♦

TV or Not TV

That is the Question

by Maren Stark-Schmidt

"All man's miseries derive from not being able to sit quietly in a room alone."

— Blaise Pascal (1623-1662)

"I can tell you exactly the year that my students changed," my college professor told our class in the 1970s. "I'd ask a question and nobody made any attempt to answer it. They thought they were watching TV. My students expected me to give them the answer."

And so it goes.

Today, our children are more tuned in than ever to TV, DVD's, video games, computers, text-messaging cell phones, and personal music devices. With so many devices turned on, what have our children tuned out?

Silence and the ability to listen to themselves. During our children's day, when do they have quiet time to think their own thoughts and reflect on their own lives?

How can we help our children unplug from other people's voices and dramas and tap into listening to their own voices?

Be the adult in charge. Use common-sense rules and keep television and computers out of bedrooms. Keep computers in common areas so that the screens are easy to monitor. Make rules limiting phone and other devices. Recently, I have seen children as young as five with personal cell phones and computer pads. The Kaiser Family Foundation found that American children and adolescents devote an average of 7 hours and 38 minutes to using entertainment media across a typical day, which is more than 53 hours a week. The American Academy of Pediatrics recommends limiting screen time to two hours or less for children over the age of two. For children under two years, they recommended no screen time.

Use low-tech devices to engage your children. Jigsaw puzzles, reading books out loud, cooking, after-dinner walks,

model building, crossword puzzles, sudoku — all these can help your child and you unplug and engage in interpersonal and intrapersonal communication.

Take a vacation from electronics. Have a 'power outage' at your house one evening a month. Sit around the fire or in the yard to watch fireflies. Play charades, board or cards games by candlelight. Fix a special snack and enjoy each other's company.

Turn off your electronic media for a week. If your power-outage night was a success, think about unplugging for a week. Coordinate with few friends or neighbors to plan some group activities that don't involve television, computers, or video games.

A twenty-year study on the qualities associated with success suggests that certain personal attributes contribute to one's sense of achievement. Success was defined as having positive family relations, good friends, being loved, self-approval, job satisfaction, physical and mental health, financial comfort, spiritual contentment, and an overall sense of meaning to one's life.

The qualities that contribute to the richness of life were self-awareness, being proactive, perseverance, goal-setting, effective support systems, and emotional coping strategies. Do our children's plugged in devices contribut-

ing to the building of these qualities?

The research also suggests that these characteristics may influence success and self-fulfillment more than such factors as academic performance, gender, socio-economic status, ethnicity, and intelligence quotient.

Our children need peace and quiet to think their own thoughts and to learn to enjoy being with the person they'll live with all their lives — the person in the mirror. Our children need time with family and friends to build life-long positive relationships. Let's be sure our children, tempted with a variety of electronic media, are not tuning out the ability to love their lives.

For more information about unplugging from media, visit www.turnoffyourtv.com. ♦

*Maren Stark-Schmidt, an award-winning teacher and writer, founded a Montessori school, and holds a Masters of Education from Loyola College in Maryland. She has over twenty-five years experience working with young children and holds teaching credentials from the Association Montessori Internationale. She currently writes a syndicated parenting column, available at www.KidsTalkNews.com and recently completed a book, *Understanding Montessori: A Guide For Parents*. Contact her at Maren@KidsTalkNews.com. Copyright 2009.*





Spotlight on Soaring Wings Montessori School Park City, Utah

**by Margot
Garfield-
Anderson**

**Director of Public
Relations
The Montessori
Foundation**



In late January, I had occasion to visit Salt Lake City, Park City and Ogden, Utah. I was attending a regional conference held by the Utah Montessori Council (now in its ninth year). Quite a trip in the middle of winter time for this south Floridian to make. But the weather cooperated and the blueness of the Utah sky and the cascading mountains in the background of every view, along with the warm and generous people I was visiting, made it so worthwhile.

Soaring Wings, one of our IMC (International Montessori Council) member schools and the organizers of the conference I was attending, have two campuses that I was looking forward to observing. Both are in the Park City area and about 8 miles apart from one another; each quite interesting and lovely in its own right. (In the interest of full disclosure, I passed the entrance to the school, had to make a u-turn on a narrow stretch of road and put the rental car right into a snow drift. I remained fixed until two road angels stopped and shoveled me out! OK, I've lived in southwestern Florida the past 13 years, have forgotten what snow is let alone how to navigate it and this was not my finest moment, but it happens.)



Soaring Wings was started, like so many other schools, by a mom who wished to have her own child receive the incredible experience of a Montessori education. Duna Strachan began her program in her family room with her daughter, Lina, son, Leith, and one other child back in 1987.

Within five years, she was looking for space to run a bigger program and, along with her husband, Bruce King, they opened Soaring Wings in the newly renovated Park City Library and Education Center. The school has Infant through Fifth-grade programs and has managed to hold its head nicely above water during these most challenging of times.

At one point about two years ago, Duna says, their enrollment had dropped to 60 percent but has steadily risen back up to about 87 percent. Utah, and especially Park City, an area very dependent upon ski resorts, snow, and the Sundance Film festival, were hard hit by the recent turn in the economy. The school responded to the change in community needs by opening a new early-morning class, a Parent/Infant class and an Upper Elementary class, which all helped to bring enrollment back.

Duna and Bruce (originally from Arizona) became involved at the state level to advocate for Montessori and have made great strides in getting Montessori schools exempt from some of the rules and regulations Montessori schools in other states are now having to fight. Since, according to Duna, Utah is still in its pioneer phase of Montessori, they have been able to show state legislators why what we do in the classroom works and needs to be looked at for its merits and why it is not *daycare*. We love hearing this news because it inspires other Montessorians to stand up and be heard so that Montessori does not become diluted.

Both Duna and Bruce are truly dedicated to Montessori and very creative in their thinking. They've had to become even more so to keep the program operating at such a great level. And whatever became of that little girl they started their program to educate? She is now a trained Montessori guide and acting head of school herself, working with her parents. And if that isn't 'gen-

erational' enough, Duna's granddaughter, Finley, is a toddler at the school as well. (I am always so envious of all the Montessori people I know who have the honor and privilege of working with their children who have gone on to become guides and have their grandchildren to watch and observe as they grow up the Montessori way. What a gift to give to them.) Members of the staff with infants are encouraged to bring their little ones with them, and they seem to have worked it out so that teachers can be near their infants while continuing to guide their classrooms without interference. This helps the teachers feel as if they are valued and their children are part of the community. The turnover in staff is low partly because of this 'perk.'

What Duna, Bruce, and Lina started this year, at the Jeremy Ranch campus was an Infant/Parent class for babies 0–18 months old. It's a one-day-a-week class, where moms are encouraged to talk about their experiences being moms and their own children in a lovely, tranquil environment. The hope is that these parents will enjoy learning about a Montessori approach with their babies and in their homes, see how the other children are flourishing in the school, observe how independent these Montessori children are and how joyful their faces are all the time, and want that for their infants as well. It seems to be working because, as I mentioned earlier, Duna and Bruce have seen a steady increase in their enrollment once again.

I spent the morning moving from classroom to classroom, watching the children and listening to the calm very soft voices the guides use in the class. I delighted in watching the children as they worked with focus and concentration independently and together.

As most parents know, the outside extension of a classroom needs to be easily accessible for children to reach. I had to inwardly chuckle as the children 'suited-up' in their snow gear, went to their outside space, and shoveled snow; whereas, here in Florida, they play in the sand. But Duna explains that having to put on all this snow gear helps them with their dressing skills earlier than later.

The Park Avenue campus in the heart of the city is a fabulous early 20th Century public school building that was being used by the Sundance film festival during my visit. The school is right in the thick of the festival activities. This year, they actually were able to open a small Upper Elementary program because many parents who chose to go the private-school route want to know that their children could stay at one school all the way through Middle School. And here the outside extension of the classroom had the older children outside sledding around the curves and hills of the campus. Gotta love it!

What lies ahead for Soaring Wings? In anticipation, Duna and Bruce have been planning a new campus located half way between the two established campuses. Bruce was generous enough to share the floor plans of the proposed building, and



they are hoping to break ground on this in the next year or so.

There are approximately 40 Montessori schools in Utah. I was fortunate enough to see four of them during my time there and meet many of the staff and administrators at the conference up in Ogden. Montessori has many looks and the children get to experience many different day-to-day activities that are specific to their regions. What makes it universal are the Practical Life skills these children master at a young age and the rich and wonderful curriculum they learn. If you ever make it out to Utah, I'd highly recommend contacting Duna, Bruce or Lina and taking a tour of their schools. Their website address is: www.soaringwings.org. ♦



SCOPE & SEQUENCE WITHIN THE MONTESSORI CURRICULUM

BY HILLARY DRINKELL
PROGRAM OFFICER
THE MONTESSORI
FOUNDATION

AUTHOR'S NOTE: FOR THE SAKE OF CLARITY WE DISTINGUISH BETWEEN CURRICULUM AND SCOPE AND SEQUENCE. WHILE THE MONTESSORI CURRICULUM IS INTEGRATED AND TENDS TO IGNORE HARSH DIVISIONS BETWEEN SUBJECTS OR DISCIPLINES IN ACTUAL CLASSROOM PRACTICE, SUCH SEPARATION IS EVIDENT IN OUR SCOPE AND SEQUENCE DOCUMENTS FOR PLANNING AND RECORD KEEPING PURPOSES.



As parents you may or may not recognize that there are very specific steps in introducing children to the many Montessori lessons and that these lessons are geared to the developmental nature of the child. When a Montessori teacher-guide is in training, she will learn the term 'preliminary exercises,' and she will know which lessons are the precursors to other lessons. Dr. Montessori was very specific about why and how lesson presentations should occur; this was not because of any personal whim, but as a result of careful, scientific observation, based on the nature and needs of the child. While the guide is responding to the individual interest and learning needs of each child, she does this in the context of a carefully planned Scope and Sequence.

What are the various sequences of lessons and their scope? To understand this we need to talk first about curriculum. Although the word 'curriculum' is sometimes used interchangeably with the content of various disciplines, curriculum theorists use the word to mean the entire educational experience. This includes not only the content, or even the intentional teaching and learning that happens at school, but also the unintentional and some-

times hidden factors. Because teacher-guides are trained to take all these factors into account (in both the environmental design and disposition of self), a Montessori education is a truly complete, complex and integrated curriculum.

The curriculum in the Primary Montessori classroom includes the following areas: sensorial, practical life, math, language, science, art, and cultural studies. In the Elementary Montessori classroom, all the separate disciplines are included into what is called the “Cosmic Curriculum.” The easily recognizable content-specific disciplines are



integrated into a broad-view approach on which a researched-based program is grounded. The Cosmic Curriculum encompasses different areas of the curriculum while tying them together and showing the interrelatedness of different subject areas. Language, math, geography, all the sciences and history are interconnected and are part of the larger picture about Earth and all things related to Earth. These big picture ideas and concepts are broken down into lesson experiences, so that students understand these concepts within the

sense of time. The sequencing of these lessons is also important.

Think of a specific math skill, such as understanding the division algorithm ...

It is of no use introducing a student to this concept unless they have an understanding of addition, subtraction and multiplication, as all these skills are needed for success in division. This example provides an obvious explanation about the sequence of lessons needed before demonstrating the division lesson. Not all lesson sequences, however, are as linear as this example and so often a school will adopt a format that works for the culture of the school, but one that also maintains the integrity of Montessori principles.

This format is generally called a Scope and Sequence and this is what ensures that teacher-guides are following expectations as upheld within the school. The Scope and Sequence may differ to some extent from school to school, but for the most part the lessons follow a very definite sequence as defined by the Montessori teacher training of the teacher-guides. A school generally adopts a Scope and Sequence that has been collaborated upon by faculty and that all are in agreement upon regarding developmental guidelines, personal experience, and the fundamentals as learned in teacher training.

A Scope and Sequence document also assists teacher-guides in assessing if a student is ‘on track’ or not.

It provides a non-judgmental approach to helping parents if a conversation needs to be had about academic issues. It also provides a level of accountability for the administration in ensuring that teacher-guides are following the pace and structure of the curriculum, as defined by the school. In a traditional environment, a Scope and Sequence has quite a rigorous pace to it; you will find, however, that this is not as true

within a Montessori environment. In a Montessori school the approach is towards mastery and not towards completion of a skill within short periods of time. The three-year age groupings allow a child to pursue mastery of a concept in a more developmentally appropriate time frame. Generally the exit outcomes as dictated by teacher training guidelines, and, which will be written in to a Scope and Sequence document, allow for mastery of skills over three years.

The area where Montessori differs from other approaches is in how we understand the concept of mastery. Dr. Montessori observed that long after children appeared to have mastered a concept they would revisit early work. This repetition of much more elementary concepts is accommodated as it clearly serves an internal need of the child and supports

In a Montessori school the approach is towards mastery and not towards completion of a skill within short periods of time.

and often precedes, the acquisition of more advanced abstract concepts. It is built into the way lessons are presented and introduced. In an elementary Montessori environment, we speak about a spiral curriculum. In effect this basically means that all concepts related to the cultural disciplines will be introduced in the lower elementary classroom and then these will be reintroduced in a more complex way, while introducing higher level concepts pertaining to the disciplines, in the upper elementary classroom. If a school goes beyond the elementary years, this process continues.

You might be wondering that if a Scope and Sequence is followed in a Montessori school, what happens to observing a child and working with his or her interests? What happens to recognizing that some children don't hit specified milestones at the same time as others? Isn't recognizing

these issues what Montessori education is all about? Well, you are correct. The Scope and Sequence document is a guideline; it is one tool in the Montessori-guide's arsenal that allows her to know what to do next with a student. It is a road map leading to the ultimate success of the student; there are many roads that can be taken and one road that is used is a Scope and Sequence document. It is not, however, the only road considered or taken in a Montessori environment, but it is one that is not often talked about. For some the idea of a Scope and Sequence is too rigid and not within keeping of an authentic Montessori environment; for others, it is the only way to go.

I would like to propose that it serves both points of view. When a teacher-guide is looking to work with a student who has a specific interest, she will be able to look up in the Scope and Sequence the many lessons that pertain to specific interests; this is extremely helpful to newer teacher-guides and to teacher-guides who feel that they have become stuck in a rut.

Many of the lesson elements in the Scope and Sequence cross over to more than one area of the overall curriculum and, as such, the Scope and Sequence is very helpful in making connections when planning lessons for students or when a student might show interest in one area but not in another; this can be truly helpful to a teacher-guide as she can work in the area of interest, but include the other area in a subtle way.

Tim Seldin talks about the *Three Streams* when referring to working with students in the Montessori Elementary program. Essentially, this concept is to aid teacher-guides in understanding how to frame the vast, complex Elementary curriculum as well as speaking to the developmental nature of the child.

The one stream includes the 'non-negotiables' – one includes introducing concepts to children that we want them to experience, but in which they don't have to reach mastery; and the other stream is the pursuit of the child's passions. A schoolwide Scope

and Sequence document allows for all three to be accommodated very easily. From a parent's perspective, a Scope and Sequence can give them a certain comfort level in that, even though we don't grade students until the Secondary program level, they have access to the vast and complex curriculum that is part of every child's Montessori experience.

Scope and Sequence Software

Often a Scope and Sequence is included in school software that is used to generate reports for parents, in which faculty can keep detailed records of lessons and experiences in the classroom, and can produce comprehensive records on each student. A software program that I particularly like is **Montessori Compass**, which has an amazing interface and is truly helpful to both faculty and administrators, and at the same time, allows for pertinent information about lessons and a child's experience during the day to be shared with parents.

As Montessorians, we try not to make too many judgment calls about students, but in all fairness to the social, emotional, and academic development of our students, this road map can provide some assistance to the teacher-guides in deciding how best to approach their lesson planning, and ultimately in creating a classroom environment in which all students thrive.

A well structured Scope and Sequence provides flexibility which allows teacher-guides to plan and present lessons that are responsive to the social, emotional and academic needs of individual students, while at the same time allowing for accurate recording and reporting. It provides parents with an understanding that there is a structure to what is happening in their child's classroom and gives the school administration a mechanism by means of which to hold all faculty accountable. In my opinion, it provides a win-win situation for students, parents, teacher-guides and administrators. ♦

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IN AFFILIATION WITH
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CELEBRATIONS OF LIFE

World Oceans Day

JUNE 8TH



Thanks to Hillary Drinkell (The Montessori Foundation) for her help updating this chapter.

"Individually we are one drop. Together we are an ocean." — Ryunosuke Satoro

Overview

To raise global awareness of the challenges faced by the international community for the world's oceans, the UN General Assembly has assigned June 8th as a day to reflect on their importance and the difficulties that the world's oceans face.

The topic of oceans and seas provides educators with a myriad of lesson options. You will be able to guide students in many fun researches and activities to help bring awareness and understanding of life's dependence on the world's oceans.

Preparation of the Child

About one week before you introduce this lesson, explain to the students that The UN General Assembly has declared a special day to encourage people to think about the world's oceans, which are in trouble and need our help. Invite the students to think about an important moment that they might have experienced regarding oceans and if they would like to share this information invite them to do so. Explain that you will be bringing in some information about oceans that you will share with the group.

The Initial Presentation

These are some facts that you might want to raise when introducing this topic while on circle time. You might want to have a globe from which the students can point out the world's oceans and the areas of the world where each ocean intersects with another.

- As of 2000 the International Hydrographic Organization recognized another ocean; the five oceans of the world are: The Pacific, Indian, Atlantic, Arctic and the newly named Southern Ocean, which is located 60 degrees south of the Equator.
- The world's oceans cover nearly three quarters of our planet's surface.
- The world's oceans provide nearly 70 percent of the oxygen in our atmosphere.
- The world's oceans provide homes for about 20 percent of the known species on Earth, but they may well be home to other species we have yet to discover, as many parts of the world's oceans are as yet unexplored.
- The world's oceans regulate climate and weather.
- The largest ocean is the Pacific Ocean, followed by the Atlantic, Indian, Southern and Arctic.

- Some of the deepest parts of each ocean are identified and are given names: these are generally termed *trenches*. The Mariana Trench is found in the Pacific Ocean; the Puerto Rico Trench is found in the Atlantic Ocean; the Java Trench is found in the Indian Ocean; the Arctic Basin is found in the Arctic, and the Southern Ocean is found in the ocean with the same name.
- The world's oceans provide food, medical and energy sources for humans all over the globe.
- Water, no matter where its source, will end up in the world's oceans.
- All life is dependent upon the health of the world's oceans – the world's oceans are a critical component of the biosphere.



Additional Lessons & Ideas

Lessons and researches on the world's oceans can range from pollution related topics, oceans' terrain, the types of animals and plants found in oceans, the diversity of habitats and ecosystems found in oceans, how oceans help meet the needs of humans, understanding ocean density and its causes, understanding variations in tides and their cause and effects, understanding weather patterns' causation as relating to oceans and understanding ocean currents and their effects.

This subject can also be used to introduce both the hydrologic (water) cycle and the carbon cycle as the world's oceans play a significant role in both cycles. It can also be part of the topic when discussing The Timeline of Life and the topic of exploration.

Preparation of the Environment

- Place as many books as possible on a shelf pertaining to the diverse aspects regarding the world's oceans.
- Display a variety of pictures that represent the diverse aspects regarding the world's oceans; you might want to use pictures relating to a specific topic for one week and switch out with another topic the next week.
- Display pictures of marine craft used in ocean exploration or which are used for traveling the world's oceans.
- Set up science experiments which can illustrate different aspects about the world's oceans: for example, you might want to set up an experiment which will help students understand the relationship between ocean salinity and the density of ocean water; an experiment that demonstrates ocean currents and wind relationships; or, an experiment that demonstrates pollution run-off and its effects on oceans – this can also take the form of a research on The Gulf of Mexico's Dead Zone in relation to the Mississippi River.
- Display items that have been found in or near the ocean.
- Encourage students to develop and prepare a meal using foods found in the ocean.



Going-Out Ideas

- Visit your local aquarium and ask for a guided tour emphasizing your focus of study, if possible.
- Students can visit a site such as Seacamp on Big Pine Key in Florida. This is a non-profit, marine science education facility which provides marine related experience for students.
- The Ocean Institute's website will provide information about the Maddie James Seaside Learning Center in CA which is scheduled to be completed in 2012 and is slated to be a marine educational center.
- Visit the website of the National Marine Institute to discover marine related field trips in the South Florida region of the USA: <http://www.marineinstitute.org>.
- The Society for Ocean Sciences also offers marine field trip experiences: <http://www.societyoceansciences.org/programs.html>.
- Another website that has information about different kinds of marine field trip experiences is the following: <http://www.ssoceanlab.com>.

Resources

Websites that might be helpful to you and your students when researching information about oceans:

<http://www.eeweek.org/oceans> • <http://www.gdrc.org/oceans/world-oceans.html> • <http://oceanservice.noaa.gov/> • http://oceanservice.noaa.gov/education/literacy/ocean_literacy.pdf • <http://sanctuaries.noaa.gov/education/teachers/welcome.html> • http://www.ngsednet.org/community/resources_category.cfm? • http://er.jsc.nasa.gov/seh/Ocean_Planet/activities/ts2siac1.pdf • http://aquarius.nasa.gov/pdfs/density_SWmix_sink.pdf • <http://www.ocean-institute.org/>



Dear Cathie A Montessori Teacher's Perspective The Cost of Montessori

by

Cathie Perolman
Nurturing Nest Montessori,
Columbia, MD

Dear Cathie,

We are starting to look at schools for our child who will be three years old this summer. While we are drawn to the Montessori Schools we have visited and the activities we see there, we are finding the price quite off setting. Can you make any justification for the price of a preschool education? Also we see such variation among the Montessori schools in our area. Isn't Montessori a brand name or a franchise?

— A Frugal Parent

Dear Frugal,

We applaud you for spending the time and energy to make a conscientious decision about your child's education! And you are so right that visiting schools, talking with the staff, and observing functioning classrooms is the best way to get a feel for what a school is all about.

I will answer your second question first. No, Montessori is not a franchise. There are approximately 5,000 Montessori schools in the US, and they are found worldwide. Each school is independent. Some are individually owned and operated; the majority are nonprofit, independent schools. Nationwide, there are also more than 400 public or charter Montessori schools. There is no one national organization that accredits Montessori schools. So while all Montessori schools ascribe to follow the writings and teachings of Dr. Maria Montessori, who founded the Method in the early 1900s, each school's freedom to interpret the writings and teachings independently account for the differences you see among Montessori Schools. Some are more nature based and others more academic in their focus. Some only go through Kindergarten, and others all the way through Secondary. Some encompass the Infant/Toddler age groups and others begin at age three.

All parents want to get the best value for their tuition dollars. But already you can see a cost benefit relation to a Montessori education. Why is a Montessori school costly? It is partly based on the extensive training that teachers undergo.

Training for Montessori teachers is roughly equivalent to a master's degree in education. Although there are wide variances in length and style of training programs, teachers generally work for a year at the Infant/Toddler and 3-6 year-old level (Primary) and two years at the 6-12 year-old level (Lower and Upper Elementary) to become trained in the philosophy and Method of Montessori education. Some of these courses are full-time; others meet once a month; and still others only for an intensive summer session. Most include a year-long internship phase, where the teacher trainee is mentored by an experienced teacher in the same classroom. All programs include both practical and written exams to ensure mastery. This is significantly different from the training of most traditional preschool or daycare teachers.

The Montessori Method is based on scientific observation and specific teaching. Each skill is broken down into small components which are taught in a child-friendly, hands-on manner. Children actually touch, move and manipulate the materials growing the pathways of their brain as they do so. Although the classroom may look free and unstructured, each activity is created for a specific learning purpose. Montessori educators are trained in all of these areas.

The Montessori materials are also quite costly. The cost of furnishing a new Montessori classroom can be about \$30,000. Each material is carefully made to a specific set of criteria. The activities

for which these materials are used require master workmanship as the materials are teaching tools and are used daily by children. They periodically need to be replaced when they are no longer visually appealing or accurate according to size. All the Montessori equipment and furnishings are aesthetically beautiful and are an important aspect of the children's environment, adding to the overall beauty and ambiance of the classroom. I think that this feature is obvious when visiting Montessori classrooms and often is enticing and drawing to both parents and children.

As you review the schools you have visited, I encourage you to consider the things that make Montessori education unique; level of teacher education, quality of the teaching materials and learning opportunities and the freedom of choice afforded to the children to follow their own learning path! Best of luck to you and your family!

Cathie Perolman is an experienced Montessori guide at the 3-6 level. She is a Montessori teacher educator and publisher of educational materials. Cathie lives in Columbia, Maryland. She can be contacted through Tomorrow's Child at: tcmag@montessori.org





MONTESSORI GRADUATES

Where are they now?

Savannah Hillebrand
NewGate School
Sarasota, FL

The NewGate community received this letter in December and wanted to share it with you ...

December 16, 2011

Dear NewGate friends and compatriots,

This past Monday evening I received a phone call that changed my life. My heart started racing the minute the woman on the line said she was an admissions counselor from Franklin College Switzerland, but when she asked me, "Are you sitting down?" I knew whatever she said next would have a profound impact on my future. And it did – she informed me of the news that has been my biggest hope and dream for the past six months: I have officially been accepted to Franklin College in Switzerland!

Receiving an acceptance into my dream school has caused me to reflect on NewGate and who I am thanks to this school. NewGate has contributed immeasurably to my independence, my ability to take responsibility for myself, and the confidence to move through life with purpose and clarity.

I came to this school in 7th grade, after my parents knew a change needed to be made. I was getting lost in the shuffle at my previous school, and I was having trouble finding my voice. There was no challenge in the coursework, and no 'big-picture' learning – it was as though students had blinders on and only had to focus on what was directly before them. I sensed the teachers didn't really want to be there; they were worn out and tired. I made no lasting friendships.

When I came to NewGate, it was as though I was out of the forest and had walked into a clearing of light and peace. The energy here was so different than what I had known before. I found teachers who loved to teach, who were committed to their students, and who believed they could learn just as much from their students as their students could from them.

For the first time, I understood what it means for a school to be a community. For me, the sense of community I found at NewGate was reflected in laying out a checkered tablecloth every day at lunchtime and eating with friends; having meaningful, philosophical discussions with my teachers in the afternoons at the bus stop, while I waited for my mom to pick me up; sitting around in a circle with my peers and acknowledging each other for special things we did that day; group gardening sessions; holiday festivals; recognition dinners, where we are honored for who we are and all we have accomplished each year ... the list goes on and on.

When I think about the fact that I will be spending my last semester of high school studying in Florence, Italy, I am filled with gratitude for this school and the support I have been given to follow my own path. But I didn't always know what my path was. When I first came here, I was

searching for who I was and what my purpose was in life. NewGate helped me find direction and discover my strengths and my passions. My teachers pushed me to think for myself, to question, to imagine, to go beyond. They saw who I was and encouraged me to be that fearlessly.

Nowhere else would I have been so supported in my decision to spend my last semester studying abroad. When I first presented the idea to my teachers, it looked very different than the final result does now. When the country of my proposed destination seemed to change every other month, Mr. Tim and Ms. Amy – who have worked closely with me throughout this process – met the fluctuation with patience and good humor. They trusted me to figure it out and understood that the path might twist and turn as I strove to create the most fulfilling experience possible. Throughout the whole process, they have stuck by me, encouraged me, and supported me as my plans evolved – just as this school has always done as I've evolved as a person over the years.

To say I have grown in this school would be an understatement – I have literally bloomed under the guidance and care of my teachers and advisers. They have not just allowed me to manifest my dream of studying abroad, but have encouraged me, and in doing so, they've fostered my ability to fully realize my true self.

Independence, strength, clarity, confidence, curiosity, direction, passion: just a few characteristics that I can thank NewGate for nurturing within me. The wings were there, but NewGate taught me how to fly.

Happy Holidays, and I look forward to seeing you all in May!

Addio per ora!

– Savannah J. Hillebrand



How Many Elephants in a Blue Whale? **Discover a Whole New Way to Measure the World** by Marcus Weeks

My daughter and I were celebrating our birthdays recently (her 25th, and mine I'm not mentioning), and she said, "I got you two books. Well, really one is for you and the other is for the school." It is important to understand that she went to Montessori school from two years old through thirteen years old.

Elementary students would be fascinated by this book — especially the visual learners! Elementary students are always measuring things, but there are just a lot of things in the world that are hard to imagine how big or small they are without a point of reference. This book gives children a point of reference. It is full of great illustrations and descriptions.

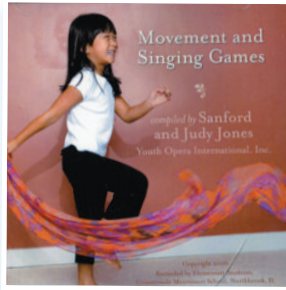
Chapters include: Length & Distance; Area, Height & Depth; Weight, Mass & Density; Volume & Storage Capacity; Population; Time; Speed; Temperature; Energy & Power; and Sound. So the answer to "How many elephants in a blue whale?" is 25. You'll have fun with the book at home or at school!



The Flights of Marceau: **Race to the Rescue** by Joe Brown Illustrated by Stephen Marchesi

Joe Brown has created a character, Marceau, a taxi cab driver. Marceau has many imaginative adventures, as Joe has written a series of books based on Marceau's adventures. This particular story is about the plight of the animals at the New Orleans Zoo during and after Hurricane Katrina. The animals had no food because of the storm damage and because all the zookeepers fled the city during the storm. Marceau successfully rescues the zoo animals with the help of many other animals that he summoned.

Joe's style of writing is poetry. His stories are poems. They make the reading interesting and fun. He has also included vocabulary words and their definitions on each page of the book. The illustrations are quite realistic, well done, and add beauty to the book. His books would appeal to elementary age children. They should be discussed with all children after reading but especially if they are read to five-year-olds or younger.



Movement and Singing Games Compiled by Sanford & Judy Jones Youth Opera International

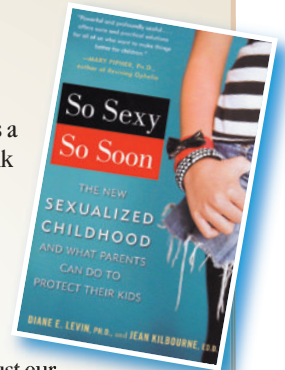
This is a wonderful collection of traditional songs including *Oats, Peas, Beans and Barley Grow*, *Rock-a-Bye Baby*, *The Muffin Man*, and *London Bridges*. What I love about this CD is that each song is done twice. The first time, it is sung by a group of children from Countryside Montessori School in Northbrook, Illinois so that the children can learn the tune, the words, and the movements. The second time is just the music so that the participants can sing and move. Included with the CD is a booklet for the group leader that gives the words and describes the movements. The activities are fun and engaging for children from 3 – 8 years old.

This CD would be great to use in a Primary or Lower Elementary class to learn about movement, at a birthday party as fun activities, or in other groups settings. You can purchase this CD from www.youthoperaintl.com.

How Many Elephants, The Flights of Marceau, and Movement & Singing Games were reviewed by Lorna McGrath of The Montessori Foundation & the NewGate School.

So Sexy So Soon: The New Sexualized Childhood & What Parents Can Do to Protect Their Kids by Diane E. Levin and Jean Kilbourne

In a day and age when our children are constantly under siege from false imagery about beauty and sex, this book is a good read for all parents. The book moved us to really think more conscientiously about how all images in television, print media, and most dangerous of all, the internet are impacting the young minds we are blessed to be shaping. Media conglomerates are targeting our kids at younger and younger ages and desensitizing them, making them insecure, and forming them into perfect little consumers. They feed these toxic images to all of us, not just our children. False images of what is beautiful, what sex is about, what place love and kindness has in real life. Even some of the most benign marketing campaigns are laced with these subtle reminders that say, "You'd really be prettier and more popular if you bought this product." They glamorize pop culture and set an unrealistic goal of how we should look and act. The book itself is an easy read and full of anecdotal evidence of the demise of our culture, which, honestly, was no surprise at this point. But it also offers some very sound advice on what to do to lessen the impact and expose the lies, which we feel is very important at a young age. Read the book, open up a discussion with your kids, and expose these lies to them before they take hold. With community, family, and schools taking action, we can take back our culture.



— Reviewed by Domitria & Richard Moore,
Parents of Two NewGate Students, Sarasota, FL

We welcome reviews. Share your love of reading with the rest of the Montessori community. Please send them to lornamcgrath@montessori.org with a scanned jpeg of the book cover (hi res/300 dpi please).

Implicit Parenting



**Implicit Parenting:
Using the Extraordinary Power
of 'Less' to Raise Calmer,
Happier & More Secure Kids**
Kim John Payne, M.Ed.
with Lisa M. Ross

Kim John Payne started out as a Montessori guide before embarking on his career as a family counselor, so much of what he says in his book will resonate with Montessori families.

He bases his work on a blueprint for change that contains four main components: streamline the home environment; establish rhythms and rituals; schedule a break in the schedule; and scale back on media and parental involvement. Each section of the book cites some examples of families encountering situations and the recommendations of Payne to apply a specific principle.

Throughout the book, he inserts balloons or callouts that boil down the very essence of each principle and, when strung together, they make incredible sense. He calls these balloons, *Quite Simply*.

Without giving away the in-depth information that follows, here are just a few ideas to get your interest peaked in reading this book from cover to cover:

- Rhythms establish a foundation of cooperation and connection.
- Too many scheduled activities may limit a child's ability to motivate and direct themselves.
- If you give a child less and less complexity, they become more interested, and this cultivates true powers of attention. Too much stuff leads to too many choices.
- It is possible to say "No thanks," to minimize the effects of screens in our homes, at least while our children are young.

If these ideas and statements sound familiar, it's probably because as Montessori parents you've heard many guides say similar things. In this fast-paced, technology-driven world we've created for ourselves, in the name of making our lives easier, we've truly forgotten about simple. This book will help you reassess your core values, realign them, and help you enjoy life more with a whole lot less.

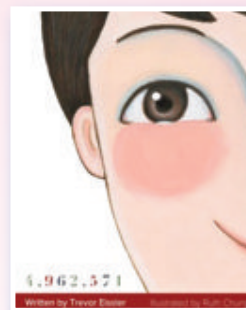
It is available through the online bookstore at www.montessori.org.

— Reviewed by Margot Garfield-Anderson
The Montessori Foundation

4,962,571
by Trevor Eissler

Sometimes a small boy gets a big idea. Who knows where big ideas come from and where those thoughts might lead?

In Trevor Eissler's debut children's book, *4,962,571*, Zachary Zane decides to count to, well, four million, nine hundred sixty-two thousand, five hundred seventy-one. Zachary uses his imagination, self-discipline, and curiosity to figure out a way to start counting and counting. Will he be able to do reach his goal?



Eissler's words are beautifully illustrated by Ruth Chung, a Montessori art teacher. Chung's pictures and Eissler's language should draw youngsters into Zachary's number adventure. Children under the age of six years love to hear an interesting story over and over again, and I predict that this book will be a favorite with the preschool crowd. It should also appeal to young readers as they begin to independently explore language and numeracy. Early Elementary children love the challenge of the enormous and will identify with Zachary's quest.

A key component of Eissler's children's books (he is planning a series) is an epilogue to parents that highlights parts of the story that relate to Montessori education, as well as encourages parents to observe a Montessori class. *4,962,571* is available through June Books at junebooks.com and other online retailers. (\$15.00, 32 pages, hardcover). See the following review for Eissler's next book in the series, *That 17th Hat*.



That 17th Hat
by Trevor Eissler

Using their imaginations to learn and to connect to the larger world is a major characteristic of elementary aged children, ages six to twelve. In Trevor Eissler's second book in his Montessori series, *That 17th Hat*, siblings use their powers of imagination to transform a rainy day into an exciting expedition. What they can do with a hat might surprise and delight you.



Marloes de Vries' illustrations present a clarity and innocence that evoke Eric Carle's or Aliki's designs and are sure to engage the young reader and listener. From the words and pictures on these pages, your child's interest and imagination may connect to maps, language, flags, music, food, history and more. Be prepared for a mission of the mind!

Using the Montessori idea of giving children the keys to the world, as well as feeding their imaginations with reality, *That 17th Hat* models how a splash of imagination leads to amazing places and experiences.

That 17th Hat is available through June Books at junebooks.com and other online retailers. (\$15.00, 32 pages, hardcover). Look for Eissler's next book in the series, *Is for North Korea*.

Trevor Eissler is author of *Montessori Madness: A Parent to Parent Argument for Montessori Education* and is a popular Montessori parenting speaker.

— both of Trevor Eissler's books reviewed by Maren Schmidt



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Tomorrow's Child OnLine is a free, additional benefit to subscribing in bulk to *Tomorrow's Child*. TCOL includes articles, videos, audio files, interviews and more that connect Montessori families and schools.

Contact Lorna McGrath
(Director of the Family Education Center) at lor-namcgrath@montessori.org for details.



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Now is the time to renew your school's standing bulk order of *Tomorrow's Child* for the 2012/13 school year.

See page 38 for information on benefits & special discounts.

Classifieds

Head of School/Director (CA)

Mel-O-Dee Montessori Center of West Los Angeles is currently searching for a highly motivated, warm and energetic person to fill the position of Head of School/Director. Our school has been educating in the traditional Montessori method for the past twenty-five years. We offer a year-round Montessori curriculum for approximately 83 children from 18 months to 6 years of age. The Head of School/Director will lead a staff of reputable and devoted teachers, some who have been with the school for over 15 years.

The ideal candidate would possess 5 years of experience as a lead Montessori teacher and at least 2 years of experience in directing a preschool.

Qualifications: An AMI or AMS primary training Montessori certification is preferred. Directorial experience in a Montessori environment is essential. Proven success in school leadership, preferably in a Montessori environment. Ability to maintain California childcare licensing regulations. Strong leadership, interpersonal and community outreach skills. Effective organizational and management skills. Excellent verbal and written communication skills. Classroom management expertise. Experience with budgeting.

Salary is competitive and commensurate with experience. Please send resume with cover letter and at least two references to: directorofmontessori@gmail.com

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VI Montessori School and International Academy, located on the beautiful island of St. Thomas in the United States Virgin Islands, is seeking an AMI Certified Primary Teacher for the 2012/2013 School Year. Must be AMI certified at the Primary level and have at least 5 years of experience as an AMI Primary Directress. Send CV to employ@vimsia.org. For additional information, please visit our website at: www.vimsia.org.

Lower Elementary Lead Teacher (VA)

Montessori School of Northern Virginia (www.msnv.org) 5+ years of experience strongly preferred. Must hold 6-9 credential and Bachelors, at minimum. Competitive salaries comparable with Fairfax County Public Schools and robust benefits.

Administrator/Director (TX):

Montessori School (licensed capacity 160 students: Infants - School-age) located in Missouri City, Texas (upscale community in Southeast Texas) next to Sugarland, TX is looking for an experienced School Administrator/Director. The successful candidate should have the following credentials: Montessori Certification; School Administrator Certification; and a minimum of three years administrative experience in a Montessori School or Preschool or similar school administrative experience. Excellent business management and organizational skills. Great attention to detail and able to supervise appropriate staff of approximately 15 Teachers and Assistant Teachers. Ability to problem solve and communicate effectively (orally and in writing) with Board of Directors, parents, staff, children and community. Information technology skills a definite plus. For additional information, visit school web site at www.siennamontessorischool.com. Send letter of interest and credentials to gifola@aol.com or fax to (301) 963-7449.

Teachers (Costa Rica)

Small Private Pre-school in Costa Rica is looking for Montessori-experienced teachers looking for a multi-cultural enriching opportunity. Please send resume, cover letter, availability and salary expectations to: info@ficustreer.com

Lead and Assistant Teachers, Coastal Montessori Charter School (SC)

The CMCS is seeking certified Montessori Lead Upper & Lower Elementary Teachers and Assistants. CMCS will open in August 2012 in Pawleys Island, SC. To view the complete job descriptions and application process, please see coastalmontessoricharter.org.

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Esperanto continued from page 19

- 8 Our children are at risk of developing *affluenza*, a sense that they are poor and financially insecure, even though they have never been hungry and live in homes much more luxurious than previous generations. One way to counter this misperception is to give them contact with other cultures that are as happy as ours, with much less material wealth. The global community of Esperanto-speaking elementary students includes such cultures, especially in Africa.
- 9 Bilingual brains are structurally better equipped to screen out distractions and concentrate. If your child has arrived in school without a second language, Esperanto is the quickest way to fix that.

- 10 Esperanto can be taught by the Montessori method, by your child's normal Montessori teacher, even if s/he is monolingual at the start. This offers all of the usual Montessori advantages of being self-paced, with flexibility to accommodate preferences and passions, as well as providing the immersion environment (which is the most successful model of language instruction) with assured continuity to completion, and a powerful role model of lifelong learning.

How good is that? (You can learn more at www.MontessoriEsperanto.org) ❖

Penelope Vos is an experienced teacher of science, art, general studies and LOTE (Languages Other Than English). She wrote *Talking to the Whole World* after a decade of teaching Esperanto LOTE in Australian schools.



Now There Are Three Ways to Purchase *Tomorrow's Child*: The Magazine with Benefits!

The Montessori Foundation always strives to help schools and parent organizations provide the most cost effective ways to get *Tomorrow's Child* magazine into the hands of parents. At the same time, in our effort to conserve natural resources and save trees, we'd like to introduce *Tomorrow's Child*, the electronic version.



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Tomorrow's Child OnLine

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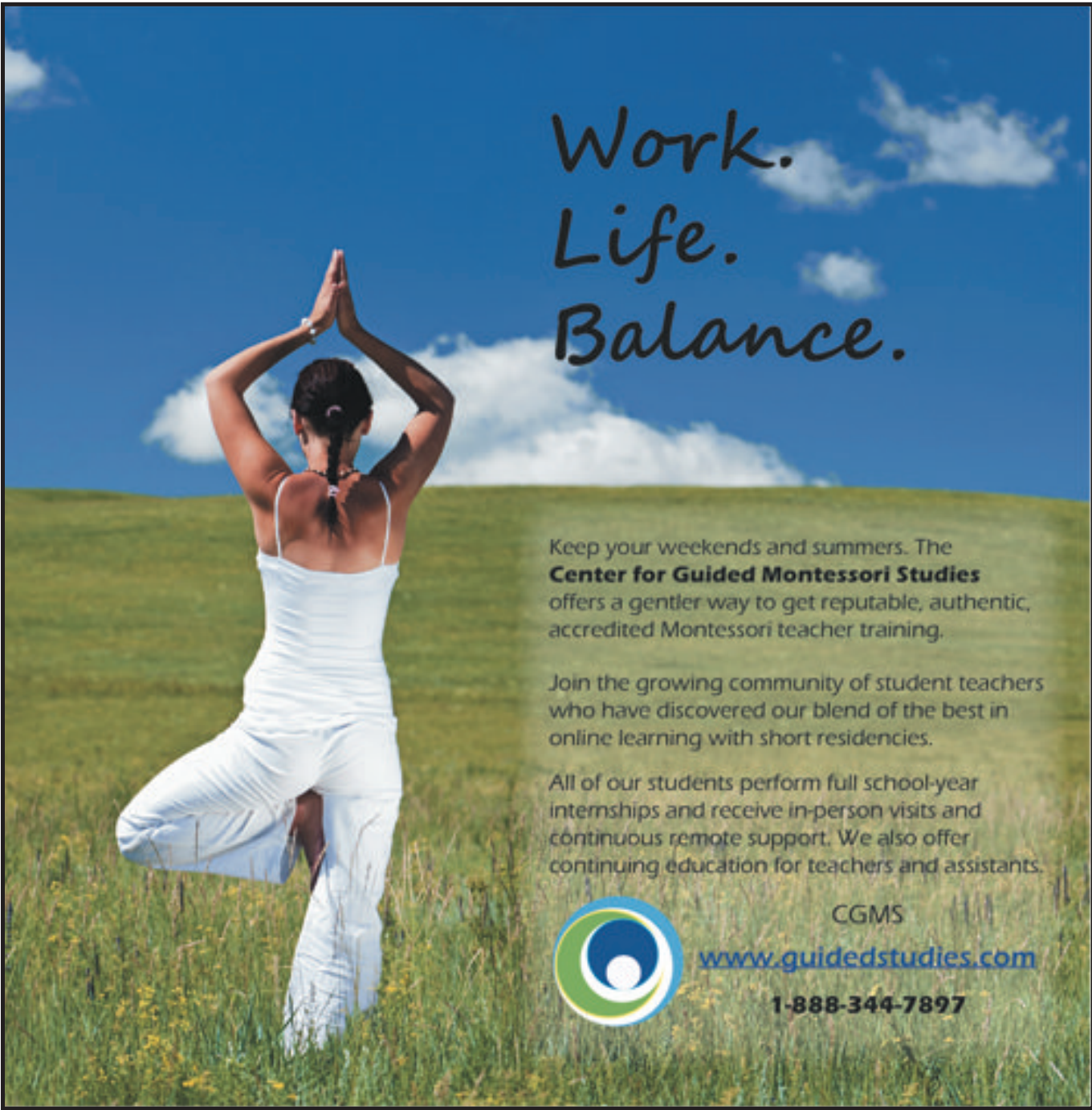
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